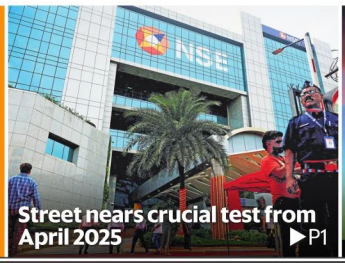
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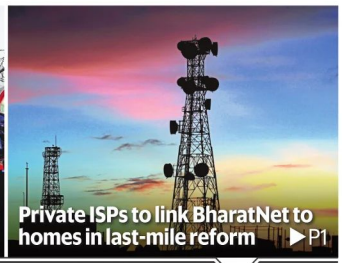
Monday, October 26, 2026

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Street nears crucial test from April 2025 ▶P1



Private ISPs to link BharatNet to homes in last-mile reform ▶P1

myconsentapp.in

myconsentapp

MyConsentApp is a **proposed Consent Manager** under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and the DPDP Rules, 2025. We work with Data Fiduciaries, the organisations that process personal data, and act for the Data Principal, the individual whose personal data is processed. Through one interoperable platform, Data Principals can give, manage, review and withdraw their consent with any Data Fiduciary. Every consent artefact, notice, withdrawal and related event goes into an **append-only, quantum-ready[1], cryptographically hash-chained ledger.** Each record is linked to the one before it, so any change, deletion or reordering can be detected. The result is a **verifiable, regulator-ready audit trail** that lets Data Principals exercise their rights and lets Data Fiduciaries prove that they comply. Built for businesses of every size.

Consent is now law.

India's data protection (DPDP) law, explained for business owners

The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and the DPDP Rules, 2025 set the rules for how organisations in India collect, use, store and erase the personal data of their customers, patients, students, staff etc. Here is what this means for your business.

1 What counts as personal data?

Anything that identifies a person. [s.2(t)]

BANKS / INSURANCE / FINTECH	HOSPITALS / PATH LABS	SHOPPING APPS / SITES	SCHOOLS / TUITIONS
PAN, Aadhaar, balances, loans etc.	**Medical reports, prescriptions, scans etc.**	**Addresses, order history etc.**	**Marks, attendance, photos etc.**

It applies to every industry.

The Act covers personal data collected digitally, or written on paper and later typed or scanned in. e.g. A paper visitor register is not covered. The same names typed into a visitor app are covered. [s.3(a)]

2 How consent works

Like a game of cricket: two sides, a score-keeper and an umpire watching it all.

The umpire: Data Protection Board of India.
Registers Consent Managers, inquires into complaints and breaches, and imposes penalties. [s.27, s.33, R.4]

SIDE ONE — Your business — DATA FIDUCIARY

- Give a clear notice and prove consent [s.5, s.6(10)]
- Make withdrawing consent easy [s.6(4)]
- Tell the Board and every affected customer of a breach without delay [s.8(5), s.8(6), R.6, R.7]
- Erase data once consent is withdrawn or the purpose is served [s.8(7), R.8]
- Get verifiable parental consent for anyone under 18 [s.9, R.10]

BUSINESS ASKS

Request → / ← Proof

IN THE MIDDLE — The score-keeper — CONSENT MANAGER

- One place to manage consent [s.2(g), s.6(7)]
- Keeps a record of every consent given [Sch.1 B]
- Cannot read the personal data [Sch.1 B]
- Registered with the Data Protection Board [s.6(9)]
- Provides audit trail of consents [Sch.1 B]

myconsentapp
myconsentapp proposes to apply for registration as a Consent Manager

CONSENT MANAGER RECORDS

Yes / No → / ← Receipt

SIDE TWO — Your customer — DATA PRINCIPAL

- Can ask for a summary of the data business holds [s.11]
- Can have it updated or erased [s.12]
- Can withdraw consent at any time [s.6(4)]
- Gets a grievance answered in 90 days [s.13, R.14]
- Can nominate someone to act for them on death or incapacity [s.14]

CUSTOMER DECIDES

Consent Manager registration opens on 13 November 2026. ***Every business that handles personal data (a Data Fiduciary) must be ready by 13 May 2027.*** *From that date, the Data Protection Board of India can fine a business up to ₹250 crore for failing to keep personal data safe, up to ₹200 crore for not reporting a data breach, up to ₹200 crore for breaking the rules on children's data, and up to ₹50 crore for any other breach of the Act.*

3 15 things myconsentapp does for you

- ✓ Quantum-ready[1], with NIST post-quantum signing
- ✓ Receipts anyone can verify
- ✓ Consent purpose by purpose, never pre-ticked
- ✓ Works with other Consent Managers
- ✓ A breach register with the 72-hour clock
- ✓ Two signatures on every consent record
- ✓ A tamper-evident ledger, kept for seven years
- ✓ Withdrawals reach your systems at once
- ✓ Rights requests and grievances in one place
- ✓ Data stored only in India, encrypted field by field
- ✓ A clear dashboard for DPOs.
- ✓ Clear notices in English and 22 Indian languages
- ✓ A mobile app for your customers *(coming soon)*
- ✓ Parent and guardian consent for children
- ✓ Live today with APIs and a sandbox

We are a proposed Consent Manager. We are not your consultants.

Have a lawyer or consultant? Good: ask them what the Act means for you. We give you the platform that asks, records and proves consent.

A business cannot be its own Consent Manager

A Consent Manager must be registered with the Board and must have no conflict of interest with the businesses it serves. [s.6(9), Sch.1 Pt B]

How to begin

1 Sign-up for free
2 Map data items and purposes
3 Test in your sandbox
4 Connect your systems and be DPDP ready

dreamscape.co.in-myconsentapp-20261026-param-tanush

Get every consent right, with proof.

Free sandbox for businesses · Free for individuals

myconsentapp.in

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Disclaimer: *General information only, not legal advice; take advice from your own lawyer or consultant. myconsentapp is a proposed Consent Manager under the DPDP Act, 2023. "s." = section of the Act; "R." and "Sch." = DPDP Rules, 2025. The dates for 13 Nov 2026 and 13 May 2027 are worked out from Rule 1. Penalties are the Act's maximums. Examples are illustrative.*

[1] ***Quantum-ready*** *· every record signed with ECDSA P-256 and ML-DSA-65 (NIST FIPS 204)*

Lexlegis.ai — Legal AI Partner

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HT BENGALURU VOL.1 NO.74

Monday, October 26, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Are India's tech workers ready for the AI era?

BY SAMIKSHA GOEL

India faces a demand-supply gap of over 3.5 times for specialized artificial intelligence talent as firms deploy the technology at scale. Compensation is, therefore, shifting from tenure and job titles to depth of AI expertise, as per industry reports. *Mint* takes a closer look.

BLOOMBERG



1 Where is the gap most pronounced?

The shortage spans both the number of professionals available and the specific skills in demand. BinQle estimates India will need 1.4 million AI professionals by 2026, against an available pool of 400,000. It also flags shortages in adjacent roles like DevOps, cloud architecture and data engineering. A TeamLease report identifies cloud as having the widest supply gap (55-60%) among four high-value skills—AI, data, cloud and cybersecurity. Generative AI follows at about 53%, with demand for talent expected to exceed one million roles by 2026. The gap in cybersecurity is 25-30%, narrowing but still significant.

2 Why can't universities fill the shortfall?

Universities degrees don't necessarily translate into job-ready skills. TeamLease Digital's report points to growing demand for specialized skills such as building AI systems, integrating them into business workflows and managing the underlying infrastructure. Traditional curricula can struggle to keep pace with rapidly evolving technologies and may not provide enough exposure to real-world deployment. Revising courses and developing practical, industry-relevant training takes time, leaving companies to play a larger role in preparing workers through specialised programmes and reskilling.

ISTOCKPHOTO



3 Which sectors are seeing the greatest disruption?

AI adoption is hitting financial services, retail, IT, healthcare, and logistics hardest: banks use it for fraud detection and risk modeling, retailers for inventory and pricing, IT firms for GenAI-automated coding and testing, healthcare providers for medical imaging, and logistics players for route optimization and warehouse management.

4 Are salaries rising as well?

The shortage of specialized, job-ready talent is driving pay up, though gains vary by role. BinQle reports 30-35% salary increases in specialized tech roles. TeamLease Digital notes entry-level AI-Core roles (GenAI, machine learning) command 2.5-3 times the pay of AI-Support roles, with projected growth of 16-21% through FY28 versus 7-8% for support functions. Senior professionals combining technical depth with architecture, governance, security, or domain knowledge command even higher premiums.

5 What does this mean for the tech industry?

The talent crunch could reshape how tech companies hire, train, and deploy workers. Employers must compete aggressively for experienced talent while investing heavily in internal reskilling initiatives. This shortage could widen the divide between AI builders and AI support staff, impacting pay and career progression. Over time, it will force companies and institutions to rethink training as traditional qualifications become a less reliable measure of workplace readiness.

QUICK EDIT

Refining job survey

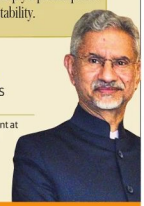
The Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) has emerged as one of the most tracked surveys conducted by the National Statistics Office (NSO). While the PLFS provides employment numbers for all major categories of employment, it has so far been unable to provide estimates for gig workers working for platforms such as Uber or Zomato.

In a major revamp, NSO has now proposed to add questions on such work from 2027 onward, and to create a separate stratum for households with digital platform workers. So far, policymakers and investors had to rely on industry figures, guestimates and projections to analyse gig work in the country. Now they will have access to official data from a nationally representative survey.

While this is a welcome change, the PLFS could also do with a couple of other tweaks. *One*, the sample design should be amended so that estimates of the salaried workforce in rural and urban India are available in the monthly bulletins. *Two*, the average earnings of workers in different categories of work should be estimated and published on a monthly basis. These figures can provide useful inputs for monetary policy.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

The world cannot advance half prosperous and half denied. In an era of intricate supply chains, of globalized markets, and of common resources, this is simply a prescription for continuous instability.



S JAISHANKAR
EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER

He made the statement at an event marking the 75th anniversary of Chinmaya Mission.

INSIDE

Mark to Market | Infosys deal wins offer it no edge >P4
Global | France dodges repeat of riots, looting with tougher security >P8
Money | Rising bond yields put gilt fund managers at a critical crossroads >P11
Views | The road ahead for the Election Commission >P12
Views | India must be careful not to sign a lopsided trade deal with the US >P13

THE WEEK AHEAD

26-30 OCT — Q2 EARNINGS
Maruti, L&T, Tata Steel, HUL, Asian Paints to report Q2 earnings.

26-27 OCT — BRICS PARL FORUM
India to host the 12th Brics Parliamentary Forum in New Delhi.

28 OCT — JIO IPO LISTING
Jio Platforms' ₹30,213-crore IPO is likely to list on NSE and BSE.

28 OCT — APPLE EVENT
Apple to host its 'Pro and Tell' launch experience in Los Angeles.

30-31 OCT — US G20 MEET
The US to host G20 foreign ministers in Atlanta.

1 NOV — DELHI POLLUTION PLAN
Delhi's winter pollution plan takes effect with workplace curbs.

COLUMNS



SONALI GARG & ROBERT E.WRIGHT
A GOLDBACK-LIKE INSTRUMENT CAN HELP INDIA ADDRESS ITS RUPEE PAIN >P12



Madan Sabnavis
TAX DATA CAN TELL US MUCH ABOUT INDIA'S INCOME SKEW >P13

Manu Joseph
A SAUDI EXECUTION REMINDS HOW EASILY WE CAN REGRESS >P12



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PLAIN FACTS

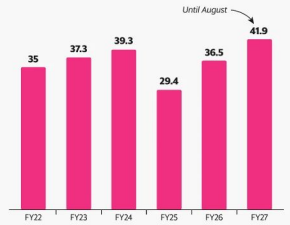
NUMBERS TO WATCH THIS WEEK

BY ANJISHNU DAS & RUPANJAL CHAUHAN

Every Monday, *Mint*'s Plain Facts highlights key data releases and announcements to watch in the week ahead. The Centre's fiscal accounts will give the picture for the first half, with the deficit already running higher than the trend. Industrial output for September is likely to continue with strong momentum, but the base effect could impact the rise. Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL) will announce its Q2 results, providing signals on how the consumer packaged goods segment is doing amid rising cost pressures. Earnings by major US technology firms will be watched for artificial intelligence-related developments. After hiking rates in September, both the US Federal Reserve and Bank of Japan are expected to stay put.

Fiscal deficit runs higher than recent trends on strong capex and higher subsidy costs

Gross fiscal deficit as a % of budgeted estimate, Apr-Sep



Source: CMIE | mint

HALF-YEAR TREND

AMID ELEVATED crude oil and fertilizer prices, the central government's fiscal accounts are facing pressures this year. The data for April-September, to be released later this week, will be watched for the assessment of the government's fiscal position in the first half of the year.

Until August, the government's fiscal deficit already stood at 41.9% of the budget estimate—higher than H1 trends in the past few years. The fiscal expansion until August came from a strong 18.2% year-on-year rise in capital expenditure, while an 8.2% increase in revenue expenditure also added pressure. At the same time, revenue collections grew only 3.3%.

This trend is expected to continue in September, with additional subsidy requirements for fuel and fertilizers adding to fiscal pressures.

According to Icra, the government is expected to overshoot the full-year fiscal deficit target of ₹16.96 trillion by ₹1.3-1.4 trillion. In 2025-26, the fiscal deficit stood at ₹15.58 trillion.

INDUSTRIAL PULSE

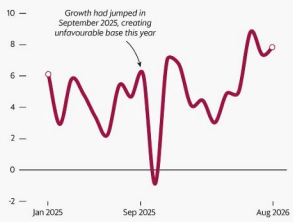
THE CENTRE will release the September industrial output data on 28 October, which will capture the industrial activity going into the festive season. Economists expect strong momentum to continue though growth may moderate from August's 8% on-year growth due to base effect turning unfavourable.

While industrial activity had benefitted from strong anticipation of demand from goods and services tax (GST) cuts last year, factories this year are operating under increased price pressure and potential softening of demand. However, the breadth of strong growth in the manufacturing segment is expected to provide support.

Of the 23 manufacturing industry groups, 18 recorded on-year annual growth in August. Electrical equipment, computers and electronics, motor vehicles, and rubber and plastic products posted some of the strongest increases. While strong growth may have continued in September, elevated input costs, higher interest rates and weaker global demand are expected to weigh on activity in the second half of the year.

Industrial growth to remain strong, but base effect may pull growth down in Sep 2026

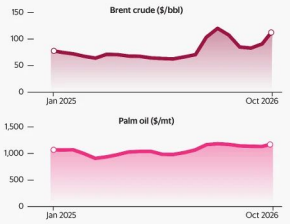
Year-on-year change in index of industrial production (in %)



Source: CMIE | mint

Elevated commodity prices may add to HUL's input cost pressures in Q2

Monthly average price of...



Source: World Bank | mint

THE PRICE TEST

HUL'S Q2 results will come against the backdrop of rising input costs, with the company having flagged a 2-5% sequential increase in input-cost inflation for the September quarter. In Q1, HUL raised prices by about 5% but passed on only half of the cost inflation to consumers, while its core operating margin narrowed 40 basis points on-year to 22.8%. Commodity prices remained elevated through Q2. The World Bank commodity data shows average crude oil prices were 71.7% higher on-year in September, while palm oil prices rose 13.8%.

Both commodities feed into HUL's cost base, through soap ingredients and crude-linked chemicals and packaging materials. The rise in crude prices towards the end of the quarter could add further to costs, although the impact will depend on procurement and inventory cycles. Investors will focus on HUL's outlook on how the company is looking to protect its margins amid inflationary pressures without weighing much on volumes in a price-sensitive consumer market.

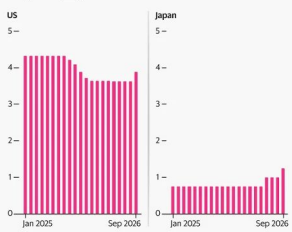
POLICY SIGNALS

THE US Federal Reserve and the Bank of Japan are expected to hold interest rates at their October meetings, after having hiked rates last month. However, persistent inflation will keep the prospect of further hikes alive in the coming months. US headline inflation stood at 3.7% in September, above the Fed's 2% target, while Japan's core inflation rose to 2.1%, exceeding the BOJ's target for the first time in nine months.

Rising oil prices linked to the West Asia war are adding to inflationary concerns. Bond markets are also reflecting these risks: the US 10-year Treasury yield rebounded to nearly 5% on 23 October, while Japan's 10-year government bond yield remained elevated around 3%. Higher yields raise borrowing costs for businesses and households, while increasing the discount rate investors apply to future corporate earnings. The central banks' guidance will therefore matter for bond yields, currency movements and global equity valuations, beyond the immediate rate decisions.

US and Japan could pause after the hike in September, but further tightening looms

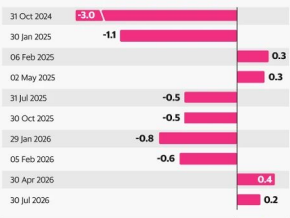
Policy rates (in %)



Source: US Federal Reserve, Bank of Japan | mint

Nifty IT often swings sharply on Microsoft and Cognizant earnings announcements

Change in the Nifty IT post earnings announcements by Microsoft and Cognizant (in %), by relevant dates



Source: Yahoo Finance, Mint calculations | mint

IT OUTLOOK

QUARTERLY RESULTS from Microsoft and Cognizant on 29 October (as per IST) for July-September period will offer Indian IT investors a read on global technology spending, AI-related spending, and demand for IT services.

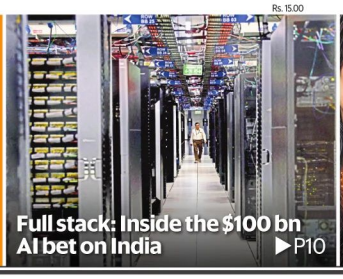
Microsoft's Azure growth and AI-related capital expenditure indicates the strength of cloud demand and Cognizant's revenue growth signals outlook on client spending on IT services. While analysts expect strong revenue growth for Microsoft, driven by AI Azure, with eyes also on margins amid aggressive infrastructure spending, Cognizant could post modest growth amid cautious IT spending. These earnings, in particular, matter for India's IT companies as they heavily operate as services partners to the global tech giants. The Nifty IT often reacts sharply to these earnings. For example, when Microsoft flagged data-centre capacity constraints and Meta Platforms warned of higher AI infrastructure costs in October 2024, the index fell over 3%. *anjishnu.das@livemint.com*

HT BENGALURU VOL. 1 NO. 74 Rs. 15.00 18 PAGES

Monday, October 26, 2026

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Full stack: Inside the $100 bn AI bet on India ▶P10



Capital shifting to IPOs: Wealth Company MF's Lunawat ▶P4

SENSEX 73,123.83 ↔ 0.00 NIFTY 22,600 ↔ 0.00 DOLLAR ₹94.94 ↔ ₹0.00 EURO ₹106.34 ↔ ₹0.00 OIL $111.21 ↑ $2.97 POUND ₹127.04 ↔ ₹0.00

Street nears crucial test from April 2025

Nifty's fall brings to view the support level seen 18 months ago

Ram Sahgal
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MUMBAI

With India's equity market under fresh pressure last week, after briefly recovering from a new 52-week low earlier this month, analysts are turning their attention to a level Nifty 50 hasn't tested since April last year.

That level is 21,743.65, the intraday low touched on 7 April last year, before the US tariff war intensified and India also began to be viewed as an anti-artificial intelligence (AI) trade, resulting in massive foreign portfolio investor (FPI) outflows.

That low involved a 17.25% drawdown in Nifty from a high of 26,277.35 on 27 September 2024, with FPIs selling cash shares worth ₹2.85 trillion between October 2024 and March 2025.

Analysts expect the level to hold for now, but warn that a breach could trigger a deeper correction and signal a shift in the market's medium-term trend.

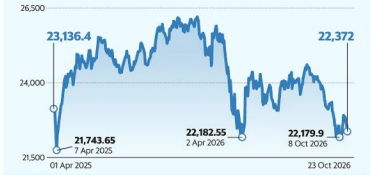
"The crucial level to watch out for is 21,743.65," said Sahaj Agrawal, senior vice-president (derivatives research) at Kotak Neo. "If it is respected, we would get a bounce back to around 23,500-23,600 to begin with. If, however, the level is decisively broken that could increase chances of a further correction, and we would have to re-assess the medium-term structure of the market."

From that low of April last year, the market took eight months to test a new high of 26,373.2 on 5 January this year on growing hopes of a resolution to India's trade deal imbroglio with the US. However, things took a turn for the worse with the outbreak of the West Asia war on 28 February.

TURN TO PAGE 6

SUPPORT STRUCTURE

Nifty hit 21,743.65 on 7 April last year, before the US tariff war intensified and also before India began to be viewed as anti-AI trade.



Source: Bloomberg mint

NIFTY TEST

ANALYSTS expect the 7 April 2025 level to hold for now

THEY warn that a breach could trigger a deeper correction

IT may also signal a shift in the market's medium-term trend

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Private ISPs to link BharatNet to homes in last-mile reform

Jatin Grover
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NEW DELHI

India is preparing to open its BharatNet optical fibre network to private internet service providers (ISPs), two officials aware of the plans said, as sluggish last-mile progress prompts a rethink of its ambitious plan to bring broadband to the hinterland. A new portal to sign up ISPs is in the works, while guidelines for their BharatNet usage are being prepared.

While India successfully built BharatNet's fibre backbone, the ₹1.39-trillion project has struggled to actually connect the households. Out of the targeted 15 million homes, only 1.64 million were connected till September end, a telecom department dashboard showed. Active connections were even less: just 947,000 in April, according to latest available data. The plan now is to get private ISPs to step in and provide home connections, using the BharatNet backbone.

"There have been multiple meetings between ISPs and the government to amend the existing guidelines. A notification is expected soon. The same has been done to expedite rural internet connectivity under the BharatNet project by allowing ISPs to serve subscribers directly," one of the two officials cited above said.



A new portal to sign up ISPs is in the works. MINT

The new guidelines are seen as positive for companies such as state-owned RailTel and other internet service providers, which could gain greater access to rural markets and expand their customer base. The rethink stems partially from the struggle of BSNL and its sub-contractors to advance rural broadband connections fast enough. Under the current setup, local entrepreneurs act

TURN TO PAGE 6

JSW MG taps its Chinese ally for 70% of purchases

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

JSW Group is looking to increase its stake in JSW MG Motor India Pvt. Ltd, but its Chinese partner Saic Motor continues to play a central role in the carmaker's supply chain. Nearly 70% of the joint venture's purchases in the fiscal year 2026 (FY26) came from Saic-linked firms, taking their total business with the Indian carmaker to about $840 million, including royalty and licence fees, regulatory filings show.

The numbers underscore the scale of its dependence on Chinese supplies and challenge of raising local sourcing.

A review of the Indian joint venture's FY26 accounts filed with corporate affairs ministry shows transactions with Saic-linked entities of about $840 million, including purchases of components and other goods worth about $820 million, and royalty and licence fees of around $20 million.

The transactions show that of JSW MG's total procurement of goods worth about $1.16 billion, over two-thirds came from Saic-controlled

TURN TO PAGE 6

DON'T MISS



BLOOMBERG

Weak monsoon prompts NBFCs to curb rural lending

NBFCs are turning cautious on rural lending as deficient monsoon rainfall and El Nino-related drought risks threaten farm incomes, consumption and borrowers' repayment capacity, prompting lenders to moderate disbursements in vulnerable areas. >P2

JSW Steel flags domestic raw material challenges

JSW Steel has called for faster development of domestic iron ore mines and investment in coal washeries to support India's long-term steel capacity ambitions, warning that expanding production will require a stronger raw material supply chain. >P7

IndiGo, Air India clear runway for shift to Navi Mumbai airport

After weeks of holding out against shifting flights from Mumbai to Navi Mumbai, IndiGo and the Air India Group have become the first carriers to unveil plans to move operations to the new airport, paving the way for the revamp of T1 at the city's existing airport. >P9

NOTE TO READERS The Media Marketing Initiatives on pages 5 and 7 are the equivalent of paid-for advertisements, and no *Mint* journalist was involved in creating them. Readers would do well to treat them as advertisements.





STRAIGHT FORWARD
SHASHI SHEKHAR

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

INDIRA GANDHI: THE PROMISE AND PRICE OF A RICH LEGACY

It was a pleasant September morning in 1982. Returning home in Allahabad I noticed a posse of Provincial Armed Constabulary (PAC) and local police standing guard in the nearby neighbourhood of George Town. I inquired about the reason for their sudden deployment. I received a counter-question: "Don't you know? The Prime Minister is coming."

Prime Minister Indira Gandhi visiting Allahabad, unannounced? What was the purpose? Pondering over the possibilities I stood there. Across the road was the bungalow of Mrs S.S. Nehru, wife of Dr. Shridhar Shridhara Nehru, a prominent Indian Civil Service (ICS) officer who was Jawaharlal Nehru's cousin and independent India's first High Commissioner to Britain. Given the close kinship, a visit by the Prime Minister to her aunt was by no means unprecedented. Still the flurry of activity was what bothered me considering the PM had to leave for an important trip to the Soviet Union within a couple of days.

When I asked a senior official I was told that Mrs Nehru was indisposed, prompting Indiraji to pay her a visit. Soon enough, two fellow journalists arrived. They were passing by and were absolutely unaware about the Prime Minister's visit.

Shortly thereafter, the PM's motorcade arrived. She was accompanied by the then Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh, Sripati Mishra. While the Prime Minister remained indoors, a visibly anxious Sripati Mishra kept pacing up and down the veranda. Unable to ignore our hectoring, he finally approached us, visibly displeased and asked us why we were making a ruckus. I urged him that the three of us were journalists seeking an audience with the Prime Minister. He grimaced and walked away.

A short while later, Indira Gandhi emerged and turned toward us with an expectant look, she gestured us to step forward. The three of us walked over to her. Following a brief three-minute interaction, she suddenly turned her gaze straight toward me. She asked: "Are you really a journalist? You look like a college student." I reassured her of my credentials. She smiled, patted my shoulder gently, and remarked: "If you are a journalist, read a bit. Panditji and PD (Tandon) used to be journalists in this very city."

On the eve of her death anniversary, stepping back from such personal anecdotes I would like to examine her political legacy with the benefit of hindsight. Till our meeting Indira Gandhi had served as Prime Minister for almost 14 years. She had declared an Emergency, suffered a crushing electoral defeat, and was relegated to political wilderness. The Janata Party administration committed a fatal political blunder by sending her to Tihar Jail, a move that backfired spectacularly.

Indira's legacy remains divided between her achievements and the erosion of democracy

The day she walked out of Tihar Jail her return to power in Delhi became inevitable. In the 1980 Lok Sabha polls, she swept back to power with 353 seats. To her fans, she was an embodiment of Durga and to her critics, she was an unabashed dictator.

Supporters proudly pointed to her decisive leadership during the 1971 war, the creation of Bangladesh, the integration of Sikkim into the Indian Union, the spread of the Green Revolution, and her willingness to lock horns with the US President Richard Nixon and create for herself a diplomatic elbow room with an astute alignment with the Soviet Union. She remains the only Prime Minister under whose watch the geopolitical map of the subcontinent was redrawn twice.

Yet, that's only one side of her ruling ledger. Indira Gandhi repeatedly weakened democratic norms, dismissing nine state governments in a stroke and forcing opposition-appointed Governors out of office. Her tenure witnessed unprecedented internal fractures within the Congress party, institutionalizing a culture of centralization at the expense of regional leadership.

The Punjab problem escalated under her watch, ending with the deployment of tanks at the Golden Temple, a move that precipitated her tragic assassination. Meanwhile, ethnic fires raged across the entire North-East. Though the Kashmir insurgency was still some years away, she, despite her Kashmiri roots, failed to forge a lasting framework to stem the rising tide of separatism.

History obliges us to evaluate decisions of historical figures with the benefit of hindsight and the context in which they were operating. Decades later, how do we weigh the balance sheet of such a polarizing figure? We inevitably judge those historic calls through our own subjective lenses. Indira Gandhi's legacy of strategic assertiveness in Indian statecraft is undeniable. It is certain that she left an indelible mark on the face of time.

Shashi Shekhar, editor-in-chief, Hindustan. *Views are personal.*

Weak monsoon prompts NBFCs to curb rural lending

NBFCs turn cautious as risks threaten farm incomes, consumption and repayment capacities

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MUMBAI

Non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) are turning cautious on rural lending as deficient monsoon rainfall and El Nino-related drought risks threaten farm incomes, consumption and borrowers' repayment capacity, prompting lenders to tighten monitoring and moderate disbursements in vulnerable areas.

Shriram Finance, Mahindra Finance, L&T Finance and HDB Financial Services flagged concentrated risks in drought-hit parts of western and southern India during their September-quarter earnings calls. While the lenders reported no broad-based deterioration in rural credit quality, they signalled a more cautious approach as weak rainfall weighs on cash flows.



Rising crude oil prices, geopolitical uncertainty and accelerating inflation are also threatening purchasing power in India's rural belt. MINT

The 2026 southwest monsoon ended at 87% of the long period average (LPA), the weakest rainfall since 2015. The emerging rural stress comes at a time when consumer demand has remained resilient despite the West Asia crisis. However, the persistent uncertain geopolitical environment, rising crude oil prices and the impact of El Nino are fuelling price gains, threatening farm incomes and rural purchasing power.

87% Long period average rainfall was recorded in 2026

India's headline retail inflation rose to 5.54% in September from 4.83% in August, while food inflation accelerated to 7.74% from 5.97%.

India's largest retail asset financier by assets under management (AUM), Shriram Finance, has lowered its FY27 AUM growth guidance to 15-17%, from 18% earlier, citing the impact of a weak monsoon and uncertainty in certain geographies. Its AUM stood at about ₹3.29 trillion at the end of September, up nearly 17% year-on-year. "Basically, because of the impact of the monsoon, we are a little cautious in certain geographies. That is the main reason to give a conservative numbers," Umesh Revankar, executive vice-chairman of Shriram Finance, said during the September earnings call on Saturday.

Revankar said Maharashtra, Karnataka and Telangana were among the worst-hit states, where the company has a sizable presence. He also said that lower agricultural output could weaken incomes, consumption and economic activity, leaving some borrowers struggling to pay installments on time.

7.74% India's retail food inflation in Sep, up from 5.97% in Aug

The company's gross stage 3 assets rose to 4.65% in July-September, from 4.64% a quarter ago and 4.57% a year earlier, and gross stage 2 assets rose to 7.04% from 6.96% a quarter ago and 6.92% a year ago. Credit cost as a share of total assets increased to 2.03% from 1.68%, with management attributing the stress largely to seasonal factors and deficient rainfall in certain regions.

Revankar said the stress was not widespread and the company's long-term credit-cost guidance remained at 2%, though costs could temporarily rise by 30-40 basis points in select geographies and products.

Under the expected credit loss framework, the Reserve Bank of India classifies loans into three stages: Stage 1 covers performing loans with no significant increase in credit risk, Stage 2 includes loans where credit risk has risen significantly, and Stage 3 comprises credit-impaired loans, generally those overdue by more than 90 days.

"Next two quarters could be challenging for the rural economy due to deficient monsoon. It could have ramifications for asset quality, particularly for NBFCs whose customers are largely self-employed. Microfinance, unsecured business loans and, to some extent, tractor financing could face pressure," said Jinay Gala, director, India Ratings and Research. "The stress may not show up immediately, but we could see further pressure on asset quality from December onwards."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Govt defers FY26 filing deadlines for firms

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The corporate affairs ministry has extended the deadline for companies to file their annual financial statements for the fiscal 2025-26 till December 31.

Besides, firms can submit their annual returns to the ministry till January 31, 2027, as per a circular. The extension of deadlines follow representations by stakeholders as they were facing issues in submitting the annual statutory filings through MCA 21 portal.

According to the circular of 24 October, the ministry said that in view of the representations received and to enable companies to complete annual statutory filings, the deadlines have been extended without paying any additional fee.

The annual financial statements in e-forms AOC-4, AOC-4 (CFS), AOC-4 (XBRL), AOC-4 NBFC (Ind AS) and AOC-4 CFS NBFC (Ind AS) for 2025-26 can be filed up to 31 December. For FY26, annual returns in e-forms MGT-7 and MGT-7A can be submitted till 31 January, 2027.

Generally, annual financial statements must be submitted within 30 days of completing Annual General Meetings and in the case of annual returns, it is 60 days. The original deadlines for 2025-26 fiscal was 31 October and 30 November 2026, respectively.

Centre extends scheme to fund post-harvest infrastructure

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Centre extends Agriculture Infrastructure Fund scheme until 31 March 2027. MINT

The Union government has approved the continuation of its flagship Agriculture Infrastructure Fund (AIF) scheme beyond 30 September 2026, extending its operational timeline until 31 March 2027. The move would bolster agricultural infrastructure and improve access to financing for projects in the farm sector, said two people aware of the development.

The extension is expected to boost investment in post-harvest infrastructure and community farming assets, improving storage, processing and supply-chain efficiency.

This is significant given that India loses agricultural produce worth ₹1.53 trillion annually to post-harvest inefficiencies. "The Department of Expenditure has conveyed its approval for extending the Agriculture Infrastructure Fund scheme until 31 March 2027. The extension will ensure continuity of the programme and give eligible beneficiaries more time to undertake agricultural infrastructure projects," said one of the two people cited earlier.

The Agriculture Infrastructure Fund scheme provides financing support for post-harvest infrastructure such as cold storages, warehouses and grading units through interest subvention and credit guarantee benefits. By facilitating the creation of such facilities closer to farms, the government aims to reduce crop wastage and help farmers store their produce until they can sell it at better prices.

According to government data reviewed by *Mint*, as of 25 October, lending institutions sanctioned about ₹1.03 trillion under the fund for 228,428 projects since launch in 2020-21. The Agriculture Infrastructure Fund scheme has mobilised over ₹1.75 trillion for the agriculture sector. The data shows that Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Gujarat are among top beneficiaries of the fund.

"The extension of the scheme ensures continued support for strengthening agricultural infrastructure and enhancing post-harvest management across the country," said Puneet Singh Thind, founder and director, Northern Farmers Mega FPO, a federation of farmer-producer organizations from five North Indian states.

Queries emailed to the Union ministry of agriculture and farmers welfare on 23 October remained unanswered till press time.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Road ministry to help states improve quality of highways

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The Centre plans to share best practices on project planning and construction. MINT

The Union road ministry wants to take its way of building highways to the states and will send senior officials and engineers to state capitals to help raise road quality across the country, said two people in the know.

The ministry will share its practices for preparing project reports, awarding contracts, planning expressways and green highways, backed by technical assistance and training. Odisha, Bihar and West Bengal expressed interest, one of the people said.

States are being encouraged to use national digital tools for project planning, construction tracking, land acquisition, accident reporting and contractor ratings. The move follows meetings with states. Consultants said common standards may improve transparency but cautioned that states face different challenges and may not want to adopt central practices wholesale.

The Union ministry of road transport and highways didn't answer *Mint*'s emailed queries till the time of going to press.

"Infrastructure development is shifting towards quality. The vision of Viksit Bharat needs high-quality road across urban and rural areas, state highways, national highways and expressways. Sharing best practises will play a key role," the second person said.

The ministry will draw on its pool of experienced engineers and officials who have worked on road and highway development to provide technical guidance to state agencies.

The Centre wants states to adopt shared digital tools, including PM GatiShakti, which allows ministries and states to map projects and identify potential conflicts early, and Data Lake, which tracks highway construction and quality checks. Bhoomi Rashi digitizes land acquisition, while the contractor rating system evaluates firms' performance. The electronic Detailed Accident Report (eDAR) system pools accident data from police, transport, health and highway authorities, helping officials identify high-risk road stretches and take corrective action.

Raghav Madan, a partner at Deloitte India, said more coordination among agencies was essential and technology may help governments identify problems and make decisions using reliable data. Common platform and benchmarks will improve transparency, project appraisal, monitoring and accountability, he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

How new land compensation rules can boost clean energy transition

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EXPLAINER

Delays in securing land and right of way for transmission lines threaten India's renewable energy expansion. On 6 October, the power ministry revised landowner compensation guidelines, setting out a framework to assess market value where circle rates fall short. States can adopt the guidelines or issue modified policies. *Mint* examines the key provisions and their implications for transmission expansion, energy security and clean energy ambitions.

What are the key features of revised guidelines?

The guidelines apply to inter-state transmission projects where compensation disputes arise because circle rates are lower than prevailing market rates. In such cases, a Market Rate Committee (MRC) will determine the land's market value. The committee will be chaired by the district magistrate, district collector or deputy commissioner and include a district-level registration department officer, the sub-divisional magistrate concerned and an administrative representative of the local civic body. MRC will base its assessment on valuations by three valuers selected from the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India's list. Compensation will be paid as a one-time, upfront amount for the stretch covered by the detailed on-site work plan submitted by a transmission service provider to the district authority.



Tower-base compensation has been set at 200% of the market value, MINT

How will land value and compensation to landowners be determined?

The three valuers must submit their individual assessments to the district administration within 21 days. Where necessary, the highest and lowest valuations will be normalized to within 20% of the median. The final market rate will be the average of the three valuations after normalization.

Compensation for the tower-base area will be 200% of market value. This area comprises the land enclosed by the tower's legs at ground level, plus a one-metre extension on each side. For the right-of-way corridor, compensation will be 30% of market value in rural areas, 45% in municipalities, nagar panchayats and notified urban planning areas, and 60% in municipal corporations and notified metropolitan areas. The norms also allow alternative compensation where landowners have been offered or accepted compensation under a state or Union territory's Transfer of Development Rights policy.

How can landowners challenge compensations?

Any party aggrieved by an MRC decision may appeal to an authority notified by the state government within 30 days of the rate being notified. The appeal will be admitted only if the aggrieved party agrees to the commencement of work at the site while the compensation claim is adjudicated. The appellate authority's decision will be final and binding, with no further appeal permitted under the guidelines.

Why do the rules matter?

The right-of-way clearances and land acquisition are key obstacles to expanding transmission capacity. The resulting constraints have contributed to the curtailment of solar generation, raising concerns about India's ability to integrate renewable energy and meet a target of installing 500GW of non-fossil-fuel-based capacity by 2030. The revised rules seek to address one of the obstacles to building transmission infrastructure.

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*Monday to Saturday, 8 AM to 9 PM. Call charges applicable. #Source: AMFI.

Nippon India Mutual Fund, MF/022/95/1

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S&P BSE Sensex		Nifty 50		Nifty 500		Nifty Next 50		Nifty 100		S&P BSE Mid-cap		S&P BSE Small Cap	
CLOSE	73,123.83	CLOSE	22,600	CLOSE	21,427.6	CLOSE	65,828.6	CLOSE	23,465.05	CLOSE	15,143.47	CLOSE	6,440.65
1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-2.15	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-2.36	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-3.78	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-4.58	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-2.77	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-5.41	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-6.86
1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-2.25	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-3.59	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.55	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-9.12	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-4.64	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-10.73	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-11.01
3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-4.01	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.06	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.50	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-8.09	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.62	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-9.12	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.90
6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-4.78	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.53	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.26	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.79	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.56	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.98	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-2.03
1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-12.27	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-11.48	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-8.68	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-3.78	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-10.16	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-6.47	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-5.69



EAAA is looking to raise around ₹1,200 crore through its initial public offering. ISTOCKPHOTO

What investors should know about EAAA IPO

Niti Kiran & Mayur Bhaterao
MUMBAI

EAAA India Alternatives Ltd, backed by Edelweiss Alternatives, is an alternative investment platform focused on real assets and private credit. Institutional clients account for 49.32% of its assets under management (AUM), and non-institutional clients contribute the rest.

The company is looking to raise around ₹1,200 crore through its initial public offering (IPO), at a price band of ₹1,585-1,665 per share. The issue opens on 26 October. At the upper end of the price band, EAAA India Alternatives would have an implied market capitalization of ₹10,765 crore.

EAAA is valued at 40.6 times its FY26 earnings at the upper end of the IPO price band, according to SBI Securities

How does EAAA's platform model generate revenue, and how much of its AUM is locked in for the long term?

EAAA invests across equity, quasi-equity and debt instruments, including convertible debt, and generates income through three primary streams: management and advisory fees, variable additional returns and general partner (GP) income.

About 77% of the company's AUM comes from repeat customers. Its funds are also close-ended, with investors committing capital for periods ranging from 4.5 to 10 years, according to the red herring prospectus (RHP).

How strong is EAAA's fundraising engine?

EAAA raised commitments of approximately ₹47,526.3 crore over the three financial years and the three months ended 30 June 2026, according to the prospectus.

Its four flagship verticals are in their third and fourth vintages and together account for more than 64% of AUM. In its flagship private credit verticals, the company has completed 190 deals, deploying more than ₹42,407.9 crore, the prospectus said.

How do its financials stack up?

EAAA's financial performance is driven by fee-paying assets under management (FPAUM), management fees, variable additional returns and other income from managing alternative investment funds (AIFs) and related products.

Does EAAA offer an attractive risk-adjusted valuation?

EAAA is valued at 40.6 times its FY26 earnings at the upper end of the IPO price band, according to SBI Securities. The valuation appears to factor in much of the firm's growth potential and business strengths, it said.

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Infosys deal wins offer it no edge

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Infosys has once again lowered its FY27 constant-currency (CC) revenue guidance to 1-2%, down from 1.5-3% earlier and 1.5-3.5% at the start of the fiscal year. Announcing its September quarter (Q2FY27) results, the company said a shift toward offshore delivery and a deal exit could hit FY27 growth by 1.8-2%.

This signals a slower-than-expected second half, raising fears of underperformance against peers. By comparison, HCL Technologies delivered 2.3% revenue growth in Q2 and raised its overall revenue guidance to 2.5-4% from 1-4%. While Infosys outpaced Tata Consultancy Services' (TCS) 0.5% growth, that provides little comfort.

"Infosys has the highest exposure to application services among tier-1 Indian IT companies, a service line structurally more vulnerable to AI-driven deflation," said Systematix Shares and Stocks (India). The revised guidance implies limited organic growth of 0% to +0.5%, compared with the previous estimate of -0.2% to +1.3%, it added. Organic growth protects profit margins and avoids high financial and integration risks of mergers and acquisitions.

Strong suit
Infosys saw impressive deal wins in Q2FY27 with healthy contribution from new projects.



Source: Company, Systematix Research
mint
PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

Notably, Infosys delivered modest back-to-back performances in Q1 and Q2—traditionally two of its strongest quarters. Sequential CC revenue grew 1.2% in Q2FY27, missing consensus estimates slightly, with around 40 basis points coming from acquisitions. Soft volumes, muted pricing amid intense competition, AI-led productivity deflation, and cautious discretionary spending weighed on performance. The retail and hi-tech verticals bore the brunt of lower third-party revenues and client-specific slowdowns, while financial services, energy & utilities, and manufacturing fared relatively better. Meanwhile, AI revenue expanded to 10.5% of overall revenue in Q2, up from 8.2% in Q1.

Earnings before interest and tax (Ebit) margin fell 10 bps sequentially to 21%, hurt by higher customer support costs and acquisition-related consolidation, which were partly set off by rupee depreciation and benefits from Project Maximus. While Infosys retained its FY27 Ebit margin guidance of 20-22%, it faces headwinds from the October/January wage hikes in H2.

CONTRACT BONANZA

INFOSYS won 19 large deals in Q2FY27, driving large-deals TCV to $5.2 billion

THE company's blockbuster deal wins bolster revenue growth visibility for FY28

Deal wins stood out. Infosys won 19 large deals in Q2FY27, driving large-deals total contract value (TCV) to $5.2 billion, up 44% sequentially and 68% year-on-year, with 62% representing net-new business. In contrast, TCS saw its deal TCV fall 4% year-on-year, while HCL and Tech Mahindra reported 27% and 25% growth in new deal wins, respectively. For LTM, order inflow TCV fell by 21% year-on-year. Infosys's blockbuster deal wins bolster revenue growth visibility for FY28 as the mega-deal transitions are only expected to begin in the second half of Q4FY27.

Can a stronger deal pipeline guarantee faster revenue conversion? Not really. Q3 and Q4 are weak, marred by furloughs.

"With H1 revenue growth at 1.9%, guidance implies minimal sequential traction in H2. FY27 looks to be turning out to be a washout year with about 1.7% growth coming from acquisitions, so organic growth is likely to be flat to negative for FY27," said Dolat Capital.

A guidance cut despite robust deal wins and solid hiring has led to downgrades in earnings estimates. In 2026 so far, the Infosys stock is down 28%, trading at FY28 price-to-earnings multiple of 14.5—a discount to TCS, HCL and Tech Mahindra, showed *Bloomberg* data. With pressure on revenue and margins likely in H2FY27, this gap could widen.

"We estimate revenue growth of 1.1%/1.9% year-on-year CC in FY27/FY28, and expect Infosys to grow slower than HCL, TCS and Tech Mahindra in both years, based on our estimates," said Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

BERTIE FIGHTS OFF THE SONG OF TURBO-CHARGED RETURNS

MARKETS *Bertie*

It had been borne in upon Bertie on countless occasions that a phone call from his winsome private banker Natasha was a prelude to poor investment decisions, and yet he always answered. Our man evidently lacked Odysseus's resolve to tie himself to his ship's mast in order not to fall prey to the sirens' song.

"Hello sir! How are you? Long time". Natasha began in her lilting sales voice. Bertie realised how scores of sailors who got shipwrecked on the island of the sirens must have felt. One knew that the song was pulling one towards one's certain demise but it was so alluring that one still steered towards it. "Am good, Natasha. How have you been?" Bertie attempted his formal voice.

"When can I come over, Bert? Let us review your portfolio na." Natasha continued. "We have some great new products which you will love". Bertie could see the rocks on the jagged coastline but he was no longer in charge of the words emanating from his mouth. "Next week. Fat Cats Club."

"Sure sir. Can't wait" Natasha hung up. Bertie imagined her doing the not-so-nice Leonardo DiCaprio gesture from Wolf of Wall Street after he had hung up on a naive client.

At Fat Cats Club the following week, Bertie looked at his portfolio returns and discovered a new meaning of the word 'equity'—everything was equally bad. He feebly vocalised this concern: "This is bad, Natasha".

"But you know how the markets have been na. Who better than you to know it? Everybody in our office loves to hear your market views." Natasha had pulled a clever one. She had not only wrapped the stench of bad returns in a bouquet of flattery but also managed to deflect the blame for poor returns to Bertie.

"So, what now?" asked a troubled Bertie, gazing at Natasha with hopeful eyes.

She had a twinkle in her eye as if she was going to pull out a black rabbit from her expensive handbag. "We have just the thing," she said. Bertie was ready to hang on to any scrap of wood that would keep him afloat in the sea of anxiety that he was drowning in.


TARUN KUMAR SAHU/MINT

"It's called Turbo Returns Strategy". Instead of a rabbit Natasha pulled a laptop from her handbag and flipped open a presentation. The first few pages were about how the turbo returns strategy was conceptualised and run by engineers and scientists; not finance people. Bertie was being pelted with jargon—Delta One, Option Greeks, low latency, high frequency and by Slide number 26 he had had enough. "Sounds impressive" he said. "It is, na?" said Natasha.

"But what exactly do I have to do to turbo charge the returns."

"It's simple," said Natasha. Bertie later noticed that it was so simple that there was no slide about it.

"Yes, your portfolio is not doing well but you have some solid sized assets with us". This time both of them smiled albeit for different reasons. "You just have to pledge it with us. I will get you the best rate and lowest haircut. And then you give us some money to put up as margin."

"How much would that be?" asked Bertie.

"A few crores!" Natasha had a knack of saying these things in a nonchalant way.

"And then leave it to the boys!" she grinned. The boys in question being the aforesaid engineers and scientists. "They will use all their engineering, math and science skills to produce great returns for you even if the market goes down"

"But what if the turbo strategy suffers losses and the margin money gets used up? What if my pledged portfolio gets liquidated? I will end up with a big hole." Bertie asked. "It's never happened Bert," Natasha was prepared for this. She showed Turbo Returns strategy's 15-month track record of dazzling returns, half of which had been achieved in the personal account of one of the scientists and engineers.

Bertie was being pelted with jargon—Delta One, Option Greeks, low latency

Bertie nodded. "So, we are good to go?" asked Natasha, tilting her head slightly.

From somewhere deep within his gut, Bertie managed to produce a "Let me come back on this" while asking the hovering waiter for the bill. Natasha flashed another practiced smile. "Always careful, my Bert. I like that. I will call you tomorrow."

It's been twenty-four hours since Bertie and Natasha parted and he knows that his phone can ring any time now. He also knows that he does not have the will power to fend off another playlist of siren songs.

Bertie is a Mumbai-based fund manager whose compliance department wishes him to cough twice before speaking and then decide not to say it after all.

'Capital shifting from secondary market to ₹5 trillion IPO pipeline'

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Capital is actively shifting from the secondary market into a massive ₹5 trillion primary market pipeline, as investors reallocate liquidity toward initial public offerings (IPOs) and qualified institutional placements (QIPs) amid a subdued broader market, according to Madhu Lunawat, founder of The Wealth Company Mutual Fund.

INTERVIEW

Speaking to *Mint*, Lunawat noted that while retail investors are chasing small- and mid-cap stocks to beat a perceived personal inflation rate of 10-12%, foreign institutional investors (FIIs) remain cautious due to elevated valuations, currency depreciation, and heavy existing exposure to private banks.

On the lack of significant FII inflows into India, Lunawat said foreign investors are struggling to find high-quality Indian companies that offer reasonable valuations and sustainable growth, noting that companies growing at 60-70% are relatively rare in the Indian market.

Edited excerpts:

Global AI and tech stocks are seeing a correction, but we are not seeing a meaningful shift in foreign institutional investor flows towards India. Why is that, and could this trend change?

The Indian market is highly polarized. Some high-quality stocks are available at attractive valuations, but investors are largely ignoring them. At the same time, certain expensive stocks continue to attract significant interest, even when their valuations are difficult to justify.

In India, companies growing at 60-70% are far less common. Those that do achieve such growth may be loss-making or trade at extremely high valuations.

For foreign investors, the challenge is finding high-quality Indian companies that are reasonably valued and capable of sustaining strong growth. They also need to account for currency depreciation, which can erode returns. The rupee has depreciated by around 4-5% over the past year, making valuations even more important.

Foreign investors are already heavily invested in sectors such as private banking, leaving limited room for additional allocations to areas where they have built substantial positions historically. Until they find more attractive investment opportunities in India, there is little reason for them to increase their exposure significantly.



We are already facing inflationary pressures because of high crude prices and the possibility of El Niño affecting agricultural output. Do you see inflation as a major risk for the markets right now, or are there bigger issues to address?

Supply-side shocks do not necessarily cause structural inflation. They are often temporary and tend to correct over time. The more important structural issue is currency depreciation. Supply-side inflation can ease relatively quickly. Commodity prices may rise sharply and subsequently correct, but that is not necessarily the underlying structural problem.

How do you see these factors affecting the markets?

The impact is not fully reflected in the market because yields have not risen proportionately. Individuals may feel that their personal inflation rate is around 10-12%, while yields are closer to 7%. As a result, investment returns may not adequately compensate them for the inflation they experience.

This also helps explain the substantial flows into small- and mid-cap funds. Investors seeking higher returns may find that large-cap companies are not delivering sufficient growth to justify significant price appreciation. Small- and mid-cap companies, on the other hand, offer greater perceived growth opportunities, attracting capital even at higher valuations.

How do you view the current IPO pipeline? We have seen strong subscription numbers for large IPOs recently, even though the broader market has been relatively subdued. What explains this contrast?

The amount of money in the system is relatively fixed, although it may be growing by around 5-7%. Capital is simply moving from one pocket to another. Money is flowing out of the secondary market and into the primary market through IPOs, QIPs and other fundraising activities. Investors are reallocating capital from listed stocks, which can be sold relatively easily, into other segments of the market. This assumes significance as there are nearly ₹2 trillion worth of Sebi-approved IPOs in the pipeline. Then there are nearly 130 IPOs worth over ₹3 trillion that have been filed with Sebi and are waiting for approval.

> The amount of money in the system is relatively fixed, although it may be growing by around 5-7%.
> **Madhu Lunawat**
> Founder of The Wealth Company Mutual Fund

It has been more than a year since you began operations. What have you seen so far?

When we started, we were clear that we would follow the distributor-led model rather than the direct route. We have not faced the redemption concerns that often come up in the industry because our distributors take care of clients. During uncertain times, like now, investors need someone to guide them and this model has worked well for us.

Initially, we were hesitant about setting up offices, but we realised that tier II and tier III locations require a strong local presence and personal interaction. Opening offices in smaller cities has helped us build scale. Also, we launched a dozen mutual fund schemes in our first year along with a specialized investment fund (SIF).

You have been encouraging people to become mutual fund distributors. How does participation look now?

We have trained 20,000 distributors so far. It is still low in the total pool of MFDs (mutual fund distributors) but it will increase. When we started training them we realized 90% of the distributors did not have websites or a LinkedIn account. Most relied primarily on Facebook. These training programmes helped them build their digital presence.

We also launched a 'Lite' course for certified financial planners. The traditional CFP programme typically takes 18-24 months to complete and can be expensive for smaller distributors. Our programme focuses on practical skills that are often not covered in the NISM (National Institute of Securities Markets) curriculum, such as conducting portfolio reviews and implementing asset-allocation strategies. We are actively working towards improving various aspects related to MFDs, including reach, penetration, skillset and service quality that would finally benefit the vast investor community.

Wow! Momo to raise ₹300 crore

The company plans restaurant expansion ahead of IPO

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Quick-service restaurant chain Wow! Momo Foods is preparing to expand overseas while lining up a ₹250-300 crore fundraise to fuel its restaurant business in India, ahead of a potential initial public offering (IPO) in the next 18-24 months. The Kolkata-based company is seeking to build a larger business across restaurants and packaged foods, with international markets offering growth opportunities for both.

The company, which operates Wow! Momo, Wow! China and Wow! Chicken, plans to enter Sri Lanka by the end of 2026 through a master franchise partnership with local entity Softlogic Corp. The partners plan to open about 25 outlets in the country over the first three years. Softlogic will fund the outlets and local production, while Wow! Momo will earn fees and royalties and provide operating support, co-founder Sagar J. Daryani told *Mint*.

The United Arab Emirates (UAE) is the next market under consideration for the restaurant business, through a local partner. The US and China are longer-term targets, with entry being considered by fiscal year 2030.

Its packaged-food arm, Wow! Momo FMCG, already sells products in 14 countries. It plans to expand into the US, Malaysia, Australia, Thailand and Canada over the next 12 months, Daryani said.

The FMCG business currently contributes 12% of the company's overall business, generating about ₹10 crore a month, he said. The company expects its share to rise to 20% by the end of the year. FMCG is also more profitable than the restaurant business, Daryani said.

The firm expects its international business, combining restaurant operations and FMCG exports, to exceed ₹100-120 crore in revenue in 2-3 years. FMCG is growing at about 100% annually, albeit on a smaller base, compared with 20-25% growth in the restaurant business.



Wow! Momo is targeting ₹1,050 crore in FY27 revenue, up from about ₹830 crore in FY26 MINT

Mint has learnt that Wow! Momo has planned a ₹250-300 crore fundraise to finance its restaurant expansion in India. The founders could participate in the round alongside incoming investors.

The proceeds will support new store openings and working capital, as well as the repayment of some debt. The company has previously indicated that it would consider a potential IPO before the end of 2028.

Daryani did not comment on the proposed fundraise or the IPO plans. The firm expects to close FY27 with revenue of approximately ₹1,050 crore, driven by expansion across its restaurant and retail businesses.

Wow! Momo reported revenue of about ₹830 crore in FY26, up from ₹630 crore in FY25, according to its latest available data. It currently operates around 860 outlets across its three restaurant brands and expects to end FY27 with about 910 outlets, before accelerating openings in FY28. The company has raised about ₹625 crore since its inception.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

GLOBAL EXPANSION

THE company plans to enter Sri Lanka by end-2026, opening about 25 outlets over three years

ITS packaged-food arm, Wow! Momo FMCG, plans to enter five more countries in the next 12 months

MINT MEDIA MARKETING INITIATIVE

Why diversification matters: Don't put all your eggs in one basket

smarTomorrows by CANARA ROBECO Mutual Fund
An Investor education and awareness initiative

Simply put, diversification means spreading your investments across different securities, sectors, or asset classes so that the performance of any single investment tend to have relatively smaller impact on your overall portfolio.

The saying, "Don't put all your eggs in one basket," captures the essence of diversification. If a significant portion of your savings is invested in a single stock, sector, or asset, a performance in that one investment could have a greater impact on portfolio. By diversifying, investors can reduce the impact of such risk by spreading investments across various securities, sectors, or assets.

Mutual funds naturally provide diversification by investing in a portfolio of securities, in accordance with their respective investment objectives, asset allocation patterns, and regulatory requirements. This means that instead of relying on the performance of just one company or investment, your portfolio benefits from exposure to a broader range of opportunities.



Mr Investor: I recently bought shares of a company that's doing really well. Should I invest all my money in it?

Mr Mutual Fund: While it may be tempting to invest more in an investment that's performing well, concentrating your portfolio in a single stock or sector can also increases risk.

Imagine two investors. Rohan invests all his savings in shares of a single technology company. Meera invests in a diversified equity mutual fund that holds securities across multiple sectors such as banking, healthcare, technology and consumer goods. If the technology sector experiences a temporary slowdown, Rohan's portfolio could be significantly affected, while Meera's portfolio may be affected as well; however, diversification across sectors may help reduce the impact arising from exposure to a single sector.

Diversification can take different forms. See the table below.

Type of Diversification	Example
Across Companies	Investing in securities of multiple companies instead of a single company
Across Sectors	Exposure to multiple sectors such as banking, healthcare, technology, manufacturing and others.
Across Asset Classes	Allocation across asset classes such as equity, debt and other permitted investments based on investor's objective
Across Time	Investing periodically through approaches such as SIPs rather than investing the entire amount at a single point in time

Mr Investor: So, does diversification eliminate risk completely?

Mr Mutual Fund: No. Diversification cannot eliminate market risk and cannot prevent losses arising from adverse market conditions. However, it may help reduce the impact of risks associated with individual investments or sectors. The objective is not to avoid risk altogether but to manage it more effectively.

Mr Investor: Does that mean I should invest in as many mutual funds as possible?

Mr Mutual Fund: Not necessarily. Diversification does not simply mean holding a large number of investments or schemes. Holding too many funds with overlapping portfolios may add complexity without providing meaningful diversification. You may consider reviewing your portfolio and aligning it with your financial goals, investment horizon and risk appetite.

Diversification is a widely recognised investment principle used to manage concentration risk. While diversification cannot protect against all market movements, spreading investments may help reduce risk associated with individual investments. Investors should evaluate their investment decisions based on their financial goals, risk appetite and investment horizon.

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

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Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.



Asia's first company to secure multiple US FDA registrations at once



Lord's Mark Industries Limited (LMIL) has become, Asia's first company to secure US FDA registration for over 200 surgical, medical-care and hygiene products. The company plans to commence US exports in December 2026, marking a key milestone in its global expansion. With its Silvassa manufacturing capacity expansion completed ahead of schedule, LMIL is strengthening production readiness for international markets. Its diversified portfolio spans orthopaedic supports, rehabilitation aids, mobility solutions and hygiene essentials. The company is exploring South American markets, subject to applicable regulatory requirements.

The product portfolio includes Lords Activeguard cervical-thoracic braces, soft cervical collars, cervical and lumbar supports, abdominal belts, rib belts, chest binders, clavicle braces, shoulder immobilisers, arm slings and much more. The range further includes compression stockings, varicose-vein stockings, hernia belts, scrotal supports, pregnancy supports, pelvic binders, cervical traction kits and more.

mint Brand Studio
Lord's Mark

The hygiene and medical-care range includes Lord's Joywipes disinfectant and cleansing wipes, Lord's Magic Elastic Adhesive Bandages, IV cannula fixator elastic adhesive bandages, Lord's Wonder Cotton Crepe Bandages, Lord's Confidence adult diapers and Safelite sanitary napkins. The portfolio also features disposable hot and cold gel packs and medical tourniquets. Together, these products provide a diversified base across orthopaedic support, rehabilitation, mobility, hygiene and medical-care essentials.

The expansion positions the company to explore opportunities in a substantial global healthcare market. According to Mordor Intelligence, the US general surgical devices market is projected to grow from $6.69 billion in 2025 to $9.67 billion by 2031, registering a CAGR of 6.35%. The South American general surgical devices market is projected to increase from $1.37 billion in 2025 to $2.19 billion by 2031, at a CAGR of 8.20%. These broader market estimates highlight the potential opportunity, although the addressable market for the company will depend on individual product categories and applicable regulatory requirements.

Commenting on the development, Sachidanand Upadhyay, founder, managing director and CEO, LMIL, said, "This certification proves the strong hold of our regulatory compliance team, our product quality and our vision to make India globally recognised. With over 200 products listed with the US FDA, we are strengthening our global presence. Early completion of our Silvassa expansion enhances export readiness, advancing our vision to position India as a globally recognised healthcare manufacturing hub through quality and regulatory compliance."

The company plans to leverage its expanded manufacturing capabilities to pursue partnerships with international distributors, healthcare suppliers and institutional buyers. While the US will be the immediate export priority, South America offers a potential avenue for further expansion. Entry into individual markets will be subject to the applicable product-specific registration, import and distribution requirements.

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Startups bet on biotech moonshots

Indian startups are raring to solve some of biotech's pressing questions, entering a field once patronized by bigger rivals in the pharma industry

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On 10 October, Hyderabad-based biotech startup PopVax announced a new milestone—its broad-spectrum, fridge-stable covid-19 mRNA (messenger ribonucleic acid) had entered human trials. This is especially significant for easing distribution in developing countries with limited cold-chain infrastructure, especially in the event of another outbreak, which would require prompt deployment.

Many mRNA vaccines, which are now being developed for several diseases including cancer, require ultracold storage—in the range of -20 to -80 degrees Celsius. PopVax's candidate, which is being tested for safety in patients, can be stored in refrigerators (2-8 degrees Celsius) for over nine months.

The startup hopes to advance its platform for other infectious diseases as well as cancers, according to chief executive officer (CEO) and founder Soham Sankaran.

PopVax plans to make its covid-19 drug candidate open-source for researchers and producers after completing Phase I trials—"our gift to the world," said Sankaran.

Improving the temperature stability of mRNA vaccines is a crucial requirement, but one that few are trying to address. The research is largely happening in academic settings or in developing countries. Researchers at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) are trying to tweak formulations to be heat-resistant and have demonstrated promising results in mice. Thailand's first mRNA shot, ChulaCov19, remains stable at fridge temperatures for three months and has successfully completed phase I trials.

This is where Indian biotech stands today—on the precipice of groundbreaking development for a global patient pool, addressing access and availability, while staying abreast of global competitors.

These are, of course, still few and far. India's total R&D pipeline for novel drug research is currently pegged at roughly 225 molecules. This would be about a tenth of China's total pipeline, according to Vikash Agarwalla, India leader, healthcare practice, BCG.

What is notable, says Agarwalla, is that roughly 17% of the molecules in India's R&D pipeline are first-in-class, meaning a completely new drug or mechanism to treat a disease. This compares to China's 24%, demonstrating the quality of innovation happening in India.

mint LAB RATS

What is a drug really?

Proteins are key to almost every biological process. They send messages, catalyse chemical reactions, regulate cell growth, build structures such as collagen, and recognize foreign or abnormal molecules.

Many diseases involve proteins gone wrong. Developing treatments can, therefore, mean finding a way to interact with a disease-related protein, either directly or by altering the processes that regulate it. That is where the challenge lies, because proteins aren't simple switches—they are three-dimensional, constantly moving molecules whose shapes and interactions influence how they work.

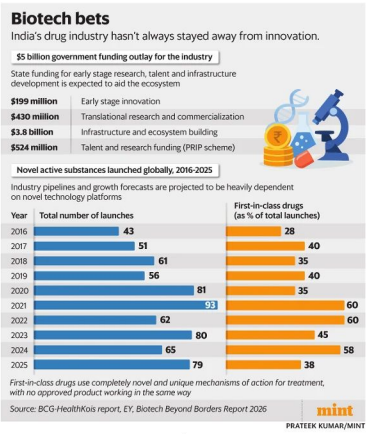
A drug must find a suitable target and interact with it to get the desired result without causing harm to the body. This lies at the heart of much modern drug discovery.

In this series, we highlight a few such promising startups. This is by no means an exhaustive list. Rather, it is a sample size designed to capture the depth and breadth of the country's biotech ecosystem.

There are a host of challenges to overcome. Sankaran of PopVax outlines the slow trial timelines and how to attract the right talent to India; Parul Ganju of Ahammune talks about initial sparse funding and how the startup advanced its drug targeting vitiligo; the three founders of Helex Inc. explain how they are trying to make a cutting-edge therapy truly affordable; the scientist-engineer founders at Peptris speak on how they are trying to build a globally competitive artificial intelligence-based drug discovery platform in a crowded market; and Kavitha Iyer Rodrigues of Zumutor underscores the ultimate biotech challenge of giving back returns to patient capital investors.



TARUN KUMAR SAHU/MINT



PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

DRUG RACE

FINDING treatments often means finding a way to interact with a disease-linked protein

AFTER a concerted effort to pursue innovation, most pharma cos have stepped back

RECENT policy efforts such as PRIP, and RDI Fund, and venture capital interest have helped

Spin round the block?

India's drug industry—known as the 'pharmacy of the world' for supplying 20% of the global generics medicines and 60% of vaccines—hasn't always stayed away from innovation.

The 1990s saw a concerted effort to pursue innovation, with Dr Reddy's, Ranbaxy, Torrent, Sun Pharma and Zydus all launching programmes. However, two decades of small-molecule R&D had led to only one drug entirely discovered and developed by an Indian company getting approved by the Indian regulator (Saroglitazar was developed by Zydus for diabetic dyslipidemia and hypertriglyceridemia; the Drug Controller General of India approved it in 2013).

By the mid-2010s, several Indian drugmakers had either shuttered or shrunk their programmes. Some, like Glenmark and Wockhardt, stuck to it doggedly, much to the ire of public markets, but have been vindicated in recent years—as evidenced by Glenmark's landmark $700 million AbbVie deal.

Startups, however, are a new story in this ecosystem. Dr Ratnesh Jain, founder of the Mumbai Biocluster and a professor at the Institute of Chemical Technology, pointed out that about 95% of innovative therapies originate from either early-stage startups or academia-linked innovators, which are typically licensed by larger firms.

Indian startups are working with much tighter funding than their peers in the US and Europe, he admitted. But they can still hold their own against larger firms, given that the playing field may not be entirely defined by funding, but rather by the science.

"In Big Pharma, one has 100 problems to solve. For a startup, there's only one problem to solve. In this case, the entire attention and energy goes to that particular problem," Jain said.

Recent policy efforts have helped. The Promotion of Research and Innovation in Pharma MedTech Sector (PRIP) scheme has approved ₹1,600 crore across 41 projects in its first tranche, and the ₹1 trillion Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund and ₹10,000 crore Biopharma Shakti scheme were announced in this year's budget.

However, core innovation requires a knowledge base in R&D, which comes from research institutions, argued Dr Manish Diwan, head of the BIRAC-RDI fund, which falls under the RDI scheme. "If our research institutions reach the next orbit of their research which is cutting edge... that's when we can attain the scale [required] for first-in-class innovation," he said. BIRAC is short for Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council, a not-for-profit set up under the Department of Biotechnology.

Biotech research and innovation hubs and incubators, like the Centre for Cellular and Molecular Platforms (C-CAMP) in Bengaluru or the Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology and ASPIRE-BioNEST in Hyderabad can help early-stage work.

Earlier this month, C-CAMP was selected as one of five focused research organizations under the RDI fund with a funding commitment of ₹500 crore.

However, these are nascent efforts and the quantum of innovation still needs to be built. Indian startups have not yet had their 'AbbVie' moment, but a few early wins and successful deals could set the tone.

This is the first in a six-part ***Mint*** *series on Biotech startups.*

Street nears crucial test from Apr 2025

FROM PAGE 1

The hostilities in the Gulf region drove Brent crude up 65% in a month to almost $120 a barrel by March end (as per financial portal investing.com), causing the Nifty to plunge to a 52-week low of 22,182.55 on 2 April, a 16% correction from its January high.

With India importing around 85% of its daily consumption of 5.5-5.6 million barrels, a jump in crude prices widens its trade deficit and weakens the rupee, impacting the stock market.

The market's fortunes fluctuated with crude since then. Nifty recovered from its 2 April low to hit a high of 24,774 on 3 August, when crude cooled off to $83.7 a barrel. However, a resumption of hostilities in the West Asia region since September again drove oil past $100 this month, dragging Nifty 50 to test a fresh 52-week low of 22,179.9 on 8 October.

Though the market bounced back 4% from the low to 23,146.15 on 16 October due to a short covering bout, the index pared half of the gains to close at 22,600 on Friday as crude again surged to $116.2 due to repeated Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia.



FPIs have sold cash shares worth ₹3.85 tn since FY27 started. REUTERS

There are worries on the home front too. The impact of rising crude prices on the broader retail inflation forced the Reserve Bank of India to increase the benchmark repo rate, at which it lends to banks, by 25 basis points to 5.5%, this month, a first hike in almost four years . The central bank also changed the policy stance to calibrated tightening from neutral, signalling that any rate cuts were off the table for now, raising concern for leveraged mid- and small-cap companies.

With markets looking shaky, analysts are not ruling out a breach of the 52-week low, but expect the 21,743.65 support to hold unless the geo-political situation worsens.

"The 21,743.65 support should hold for now, even if the 52-week low breaks," said Rohit Srivastava, founder of analytics firm IndiaCharts. "Markets are heavily oversold, with only 7 out of Nifty 50 stocks currently trading above their 50-week moving average, the lowest reading since the pandemic of March 2020," said Srivastava. "Thus, a sliver of good news—such as a resolution of the West Asia war or a trade deal with the US—could result in a rebound to the 23,600-23,700 levels to begin with."

The high crude price is acting as a strong headwind for the economy and market, said V.K. Vijayakumar, chief investment strategist at Geojit Financial Services. "So long as Brent crude remains above $100, there will be pressures on the economy and the FPIs are likely to sell the dip."

Since the beginning of this fiscal year in April, FPIs have sold cash shares worth ₹3.85 trillion, per depository data.

Pvt ISPs to connect last mile in BharatNet

FROM PAGE 1

as sub-contractors for BSNL to install home-broadband connections. In return, BSNL gives them a signup bonus and a share of the monthly subscriber revenue. Under the new model, both private and public sector ISPs will be allowed to register independently through the portal in the works, the second official said. ISPs will own customer relationships, receive direct per-connection subsidies of ₹8,900-12,900, and retain 95% of monthly subscriber revenues. BSNL will not get any revenue share, but will continue to be BharatNet's project management agency.

Queries emailed to BSNL, Department of Telecom and RailTel on Friday remained unanswered.

Launched in 2011 as the National Optical Fibre Network and later renamed BharatNet, the programme aimed to bring high-speed broadband to 250,000 Gram Panchayats within two years, a deadline that passed unmet. The target was subsequently divided into phases. In Phase I, the target was to connect 100,000 Gram Panchayats, which was completed only in December 2017. Under phase 2, the target was set to connect the remaining 150,000 gram panchayats, with a revised strategy by March 2019. As of September end, about 224,590 gram panchayats have been made connected by fiber under the BharatNet, according to the DoT dashboard.



For firms like RailTel, the new guidelines appear positive. MINT

"If private ISPs are brought into BharatNet, it will be a positive move. However, the government will have to address certain issues such as financial obligations and reporting requirements, for ease of doing business," said Rajesh Chharia, president of Internet Service Providers Association of India (ISPAI), which represents over 100 providers. According to Chharia, smaller ISPs involved in BharatNet can also voluntarily support the government's efforts on e-health, e-education, and e-governance.

While India successfully built BharatNet, the project has struggled in connecting homes

ISPs will have to submit bank guarantees or cash/insurance surety bonds equal to subsidy received, the second official added. This is to ensure accountability, with audits verifying the subsidies disbursed against the addition of new subscriber connections.

"There is a concern that having to maintain guarantees for 30 months, risk repaying subsidies if subscribers discontinue their connections. Further, maintaining such bank guarantees is an added cost alongside multiple audits which could make the process cumbersome," an industry executive said.

In August 2023, the government approved the ₹1.4 trillion amended BharatNet programme to upgrade the existing network and expand coverage to 264,000 gram panchayats. However, the project continues to face criticism over implementation delays and gaps in last-mile connectivity.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

JSW MG taps its Chinese partner Saic for 70% of purchases

FROM PAGE 1

firms, making the JV a significant revenue opportunity for the Chinese firm's ecosystem.

Overall transactions rose from about $640 million in FY25, with Saic's share of purchases a tad down from about 74% in FY25 to 70% in FY26.

Per related-party disclosures, MG procured goods from at least 10 Saic-linked entities in FY26, with the bulk from Chinese firms in the second full fiscal year since the joint venture took off in 2024.

Ji Qiwei, a Saic group veteran who held senior roles across its automotive businesses for over two decades, joined JSW MG Motor as president in January 2025 and was appointed to its board in September, company filings show.

As per the filings, JSW MG's largest purchase was from Guangxi Haoling Automotive Technology Co. Ltd, which accounted for ₹5,153.82 crore. Other major suppliers included Saic Maxus Automotive, Saic Motor International and Saic Overseas Intelligent Mobility Technology.

The transactions are classified as purchases of raw materials and traded goods, without specifying if they were individual components, assemblies or completely knocked-down kits of vehicles.

JSW Group, Saic and JSW MG Motor did not respond to emailed queries.

The joint venture recently appointed Parth Jindal as chairman, succeeding his father Sajjan Jindal, as JSW and Saic remain in discussions over future ownership and funding of the firm. Parth Jindal had said in August that "discussions between both shareholders are well underway", but did not give details. He said Saic sees India as its "next engine for growth".

JSW MG was the Jindal conglomerate's first automobile foray via a partnership with Saic, with the group now expanding via its own entities: JSW Motors for passenger vehicles and JSW Greentech for commercial vehicles. It is also in talks with Volkswagen Group for a joint venture, being seen as an attempt to broaden its global tie-ups.



The numbers underscore the scale of the firm's dependence on Chinese supplies and challenge of increasing local sourcing. REUTERS

JSW MG is expanding its operations. It sold 72,918 vehicles in FY26, up 17% from 62,501 units a year ago. It plans to expand capacity at Halol and deepen localization, with an aim to invest ₹3,000-4,000 crore in a few years.

The joint venture was formed in 2023, when JSW agreed to acquire 35% in MG Motor India, with Saic retaining 49% and balance with India's financial institutions, dealers and employees. This was launched in 2024, with a plan to expand output, boost local sourcing and bring more electric and other new-energy vehicles to India.

CHINA RELIANCE

A review of JSW MG's FY26 accounts shows transactions with Saic-linked units of about $840 million

JSW MG's largest purchase was from Guangxi Haoling Automotive Technology Co.

For Saic, the Indian business is small relative to its global size but represents a growing market for its wider ecosystem of vehicle and component suppliers. Saic Motor reported consolidated revenue of 656.2 billion yuan ($91.3 billion) in 2025, when it sold 4.51 million vehicles globally.

JSW MG saw a 40% revenue rise to ₹12,075 crore in FY26 while net loss fell to ₹931 crore from ₹1,096 crore.

"Saic's leverage isn't only its shareholding. It is also the technology, platforms, and supply chain that JSW MG depends on. JSW brings capital, local execution and a route to scale, and India's rules on investment from land-border countries still matter, even after this year's limited relaxations," said Vinay Piparsania, founder at Millenstrat Advisory and Research.

"Related-party purchases on this scale, however, will also attract transfer-pricing scrutiny, which makes it fair to ask how much of the losses are structural," he said. "Ultimately, the test is localization. Until import dependence comes down meaningfully, more Indian ownership won't automatically mean more operational independence."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Naman eyes expansion of hospitality portfolio

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Mumbai-based Shree Naman Group is targeting at least 2,500 hotel rooms over the next five years, as it looks beyond its home market to build a national hospitality portfolio through acquisitions and new developments.

The group, which owns Sofitel Mumbai BKC, has expanded its operating portfolio to around 1,000 rooms across Mumbai, Bengaluru and Pune following the acquisition of JW Marriott Bengaluru and Crowne Plaza Pune at a combined enterprise value of about ₹1,800 crore. The two hotels add around 450 rooms to a business that had approximately 370 rooms three years ago, Harsh J. Shah, director of Shree Naman Group, told *Mint*.

"From being a single micro-market hotel player, we've expanded considerably and now have a portfolio of world-class hotel assets across the country. We hope to get from our current 1,000 to at least 2,500 keys over the next five years, maybe even sooner."

Mint reported on 26 August that the group had won bids for JW Marriott Bengaluru and Crowne Plaza Pune at ₹1,800 crore. The expansion marks a shift for the group, whose hotel business was largely concentrated in Mumbai for about 15 years. Its operating portfolio also includes Ibis Mumbai BKC and Lemon Tree Hotel, Kalina BKC.

It now plans to expand into other business centres while keeping a presence in leisure destinations.

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JSW Steel flags domestic raw material challenges

India aims to scale its crude steel capacity to 600 mt and consumption to 505 mt by 2047

Dipali Banka & Nehal Chaliawala
MUMBAI

JSW Steel Ltd has called for faster development of domestic iron ore mines and investment in coal washeries to support India's long-term steel capacity ambitions, warning that expanding production will require a stronger raw material supply chain even as the country seeks to reduce import dependence.

"India has a lot of iron ore. We have to make sure that iron ore is brought out in terms of supply, and remove bottlenecks. Mines should not be allowed to stay non-functional once allocations are made. Squatting on resources has to be avoided, and people should get the mines going," Jayant Acharya, joint managing director (MD) and chief executive officer (CEO) of JSW Steel, said in an interview with *Mint*.

Acharya's comments come amid ambitious national targets. Under the draft National Steel Policy, India aims to scale its crude steel capacity to 600 million tonnes (mt) and consumption to 505 mt by 2047. As an intermediate milestone, the previous NSP policy set a target to raise crude steel production capacity to 300 mt by 2031, up from the current installed capacity of 220 mt. While India possesses substantial mineral reserves, Acharya noted that several mines remain unexplored or non-operational, restricting raw material supply as steelmakers plan these major capacity additions.

The challenge extends to coking coal, a key input in blast furnace-based steelmaking. India has historically depended on international supplies, but greater investment in coal washeries could allow domestic coal with semi-hard or semi-soft coking properties to be blended with imported coal, boosting self-reliance, he said.

A combination of domestic production and imports will remain necessary as India scales up steelmaking, he added. Steelmakers may need to import iron ore of different grades to blend with domestic supplies, depending on iron content and impurities such as alumina and silica. "Self-reliance with some imports can work if you have to go to the 600 million tonnes in the draft policy," Acharya said.



"We have to make sure that iron ore is brought out in terms of supply, and remove bottlenecks, " Jayant Acharya, joint MD and CEO of JSW Steel said. REUTERS

India's steel consumption grew 7.5% in the first half of the current financial year, strengthening the case for capacity additions. Acharya said the country's domestic demand, driven by infrastructure, construction and manufacturing, provides long-term visibility for the sector. "Unless the industry adds capacity in time, supply will lag demand," he said. India's crude steel production was 170 mt in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), while finished steel consumption was 164 mt.

JSW's current steel capacity, including overseas operations and joint ventures, stands at 37.9 mtpa, which it expects to expand to about 80 mtpa by 2032.

India's largest steelmaker will also prioritise ongoing capacity expansions at Utkal, Vijayanagar and Dolvi over its proposed green steel project at Salav, as it awaits greater clarity on natural gas availability and renewable energy capacity, Acharya said.

JSW Steel is focusing on brownfield expansions that offer lower costs and can be commissioned in phases. Its Utkal project, with a planned capacity of 10 mtpa, is estimated to cost about ₹48,000 crore, excluding associated pellet plants. Including the latter, the investment would be around ₹55,000 crore, or about $550 per tonne of capacity, Acharya said. The company also plans to complete the second phase of its JSW Vijayanagar Metallics Limited (JVML) expansion of 5 mtpa, alongside the ongoing third phase of expansion at Dolvi to scale capacity from 10 mtpa to 15 mtpa. Slated for commissioning by 2030, these projects will be funded entirely through internal accruals and generate additional cash flows for future growth.

The company has planned a 4-mtpa green steel facility at Salav in Maharashtra, based on direct reduced iron (DRI) and electric arc furnace (EAF) technology. The plant is expected to operate on renewable energy and natural gas, with a targeted carbon footprint of less than 0.7 tonnes of carbon dioxide per tonne of crude steel. However, the project will be taken up in phases once the geopolitical situation stabilises and the company has better visibility on gas supplies and renewable energy generation. "We will fix the timeline once we have better visibility on the renewable energy and natural gas required to make the green steel," Acharya said.

The company is also evaluating coal gasification but believes conventional steelmaking routes remain more viable at present.

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WILL TO STEEL

COAL washeries could reduce coking coal imports by enabling domestic coal blending

INDIA'S steel consumption grew 7.5% in the first half of the current financial year

JSW Steel favours phased brownfield expansions to keep costs low

THE company has planned a 4-mtpa green steel facility at Salav in Maharashtra

District explores venues to cut costs, counter AI threat

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District plans to focus initially on five to 10 major cities. AFP

Eternal's District is exploring investments in dedicated live-event venues, betting that physical infrastructure can lower the cost of staging concerts and give the out-of-home consumption platform a more defensible business as artificial intelligence (AI) agents threaten to disrupt online bookings.

The company is in discussions with potential partners and governments on long-term projects, including public-private partnerships, Rahul Ganjoo, chief executive of District, said in an interview with *Mint*.

"Without dedicated live-event venues, it is difficult to build a sustainable business, because you spend a large amount of money setting up a venue only to take it down within a day," Ganjoo said. Some temporary concert sites can cost over $1 million to build only to be dismantled within hours, he added. District's first bet is Terraform, a 16-acre outdoor entertainment arena in north Bengaluru, which it took over in September 2025. Its plug-and-play model includes facilities for artists, production crews, and audiences, reducing the need to build infrastructure from scratch for each concert.

Building new venues, however, will take time. Large additions to the network are unlikely within the next year, Ganjoo said. "It will be a long-drawn-out process. In the meantime, we're exploring opportunities and working with partners to identify potential venues," he added.

District plans to focus initially on five to 10 major cities, where event supply and audience demand can support regular programming. It is also engaging with stakeholders in 10 to 15 cities to assess commercial viability. Mumbai remains a particularly competitive market for concert infrastructure, Ganjoo said. The company is also exploring smaller venues for recurring events, allowing performers and formats to build audiences before moving to larger stages.

The strategy reflects a broader push to cater to consumers seeking more varied leisure experiences, from nostalgia-led concerts to weekday outings.

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NEW DELHI MUNICIPAL COUNCIL
PARKING MANAGEMENT SYSTEM DEPARTMENT

TENDER NOTICE

NDMC invites Tender (Technical & Financial Bids Separately) from the eligible qualified firms as per the eligibility conditions mentioned in the RFP for selection of Agency to Design, Develop, Supply, Implement, Operate and maintain Intelligent Integrated Parking System in Clusters 1, 2 and 3 of NDMC area.

The Last date of submission of bid is 12th November, 2026 (1500 hours IST). The details/document website can be downloaded from the website **www.ndmc.gov.in** or e-procurement website of GNCTD i.e. **http:govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in.** The Bidder/s may visit aforementioned websites to check further corrections/amendments, if any and for online submission of their bid on e-procurement website as per the Request for Proposal.

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IIFL Capital hires 4 Barclays bankers to expand wealth biz

Agnidev Bhattacharya
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MUMBAI



The hiring drive comes amid a change in ownership at the company. ISTOCKPHOTO

Fairfax-controlled IIFL Capital Services Ltd. is stepping up its push into wealth management, hiring four senior private bankers from Barclays Plc to target ultra-high-net-worth families, business promoters and non-resident Indians. Neeraj Pandey, Subir Didwania, Kunal Kapadia and Vivek Makim have joined IIFL Capital's wealth unit as senior executives, the company said on Monday. They will lead the expansion of its domestic wealth business and its Global Indian division, which manages cross-border assets for Indian families. Pandey, who will anchor the Global Indian business, spent more than seven years at Barclays leading a team focused on high-net-worth individuals and family offices. Didwania spent two decades at Barclays, most recently as a director overseeing corporate and family office relationships. Kapadia previously worked at Citibank, Deutsche Bank and Edelweiss before joining Barclays, while Makim spent 10 years at Barclays Private Bank India after stints at DSP Merrill Lynch and HSBC Private Bank.

"Talent is the ultimate differentiator in financial services. By welcoming experienced private banking professionals to IIFL Capital, we are strengthening our capabilities, deepening client relationships, and accelerating our growth ambitions," joint chief executive Prakash Bulusu told *Mint*.

The appointments build on a broader expansion that began in June 2024, when IIFL Capital named former Citibank executives Raghav Gupta and Bulusu as joint chief executives of its wealth business, alongside Amit Srivastava as senior managing partner for investments. The expansion comes as the business gains scale. According to IIFL Capital's 2026 annual report, revenue from wealth management and financial product distribution rose 12% year-on-year to ₹572 crore, accounting for nearly 22% of its total revenue.

The company hired 60 relationship managers in the last 18 months and plans to add 120 more

In March, founder Nirmal Jain said IIFL Capital aimed to increase its assets under management, which stood at ₹60,000 crore at the end of fiscal year 2026 (FY26), by 80-100% over the following two years. The company added about 60 relationship managers in the preceding 18 months and planned to recruit another 120. The hiring drive coincides with a change in ownership at the financial services firm. In May, the board approved a ₹2,000 crore preferential share issue to Canadian billionaire Prem Watsa's Fairfax Financial Holdings Ltd at ₹350 a share, making Fairfax the controlling shareholder.

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MINT MEDIA MARKETING INITIATIVE

mint The Festive Edge
LEADERS' LENS

As part of Mint's Festive Edge initiative, Leaders' Lens brings together industry perspectives on the consumer shifts, market trends and brand priorities shaping the festive season.



RIYA JOSEPH,
General Manager - Media, Britannia Industries Ltd

What is the one shift in how Indians are shopping this festive season that feels meaningfully different from last year?
Festive shopping is no longer just one big trip. It's now made up of a string of late, ten-minute decisions. Shoppers are buying closer to the day, and quick commerce already makes up 80–85% of Britannia's e-commerce. With Diwali on November 8, that window gets even tighter. So that brands are now asking "are we top of mind, and top of the app, in that moment?"

Where does a festive purchase really get decided today - at the showroom, a phone screen, or in a conversation at home?
At home, and then on the phone. People discover products on screens and in creator feeds, but the decision is still made in the household: who's visiting, what we're taking to whose house, what the kids want. The phone becomes a very important medium to carry it out, often through a quick-commerce search bar, which has become the new shelf. That's why Britannia invests in two things: being part of that home conversation, through festival rituals and regional creators, and actively taking efforts to be part of the purchase basket.

Where are consumers willing to trade up this festive season and where is value still winning over aspiration?
Consumers trade up on what others see and save on what sits in the pantry. Gifting and hosting invite novelty: our Bourbon Chocolate Modak with Bombay Sweet Shop for Ganesh Chaturthi and our festive-edition packs for Britannia Cakes in the East are examples of how serious we take festive periods and our role in the Indian household. At the same time, everyday snacking remains firmly rooted in value and continues to play an important role in how India snacks. Our role is to bring something special to festive occasions while continuing to deliver the value and accessibility consumers expect from Britannia every day.

In a festive season crowded with offers, screens, scrolls and messages, where can a brand still earn attention?
Belief is earned through culture, not clutter. Brand trust now matters more than discounts in what people buy, and trust grows when a brand speaks a region's own language. That's our "Many Indias" approach: 5050 Cheeze Dipped's Onam work with Kerala creators, built around the sadya, Marie Gold's Durga Puja activation in West Bengal, and Milk Bikis' Thirukkural campaign in Tamil Nadu. Credibility comes from being specific and consistent, and from showing up where people already celebrate.

Disclaimer: Leaders' Lens is a marketing initiative by HT Media. The news and editorial teams of Mint had no role in its creation.

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RESERVE BANK OF INDIA
www.rbi.org.in

AUCTION OF STATE GOVERNMENT SECURITIES

The following State Governments have offered to sell stock by way of auction, for an aggregate amount of **₹23,300 Crore** (Face Value).

Sr. No.	State/UT	Amount to be raised (₹ Crore)	Tenure (Year)	Type of Auction
1.	Assam	1,000	09	Yield Basis
2.	Bihar	1,000	09	Yield Basis
		2,000	Re-issue of 7.66% Bihar SGS 2041, issued on July 22, 2026	Price Basis
3.	Chhattisgarh	600	Re-issue of 7.83% Chhattisgarh SGS 2040, issued on April 15, 2026	Price Basis
		600	Re-issue of 7.82% Chhattisgarh SGS 2048, issued on April 29, 2026	Price Basis
4.	Gujarat	1,000	Re-issue of 7.96% Gujarat SGS 2035, issued on October 14, 2026	Price Basis
		1,000	Re-issue of 8.08% Gujarat SGS 2038, issued on October 21, 2026	Price Basis
5.	Himachal Pradesh	400	Re-issue of 7.77% Himachal Pradesh SGS 2049, issued on June 24, 2026	Price Basis
6.	Jharkhand	200	Re-issue of 7.30% Jharkhand SGS 2033, issued on July 08, 2026	Price Basis
7.	Keralam	1500	14	Yield Basis
8.	Manipur	300	Re-issue of 7.79% Manipur SGS 2042, issued on June 10, 2026	Price Basis
9.	Nagaland	300	09	Yield Basis
10.	Sikkim	200	Re-issue of 7.55% Sikkim SGS 2030, issued on September 30, 2026	Price Basis
		200	Re-issue of 7.98% Sikkim SGS 2042, issued on September 30, 2026	Price Basis
11.	Tamil Nadu	2,500	Re-issue of 7.80% Tamil Nadu SGS 2041, issued on June 03, 2026	Price Basis
		2,500	Re-issue of 8.14% Tamil Nadu SGS 2046, issued on October 14, 2026	Price Basis
		2,000	Re-issue of 8.21% Tamil Nadu SGS 2051, issued on October 14, 2026	Price Basis
		2,000	Re-issue of 8.18% Tamil Nadu SGS 2056, issued on October 14, 2026	Price Basis
12.	Uttar Pradesh	500	Re-issue of 7.14% Uttar Pradesh SGS 2032, issued on July 08, 2026	Price Basis
		1,000	Re-issue of 7.59% Uttar Pradesh SGS 2042, issued on July 08, 2026	Price Basis
		2,000	Re-issue of 7.95% Uttar Pradesh SGS 2051, issued on September 30, 2026	Price Basis
13.	Uttarakhand	500	Re-issue of 7.64% Uttarakhand SGS 2038, issued on August 05, 2026	Price Basis
	Total	**23,300**		

The auction will be conducted on the Reserve Bank of India Core Banking Solution (E-Kuber) system on **October 27, 2026 (Tuesday).** Individual investors can also place bids as per the non-competitive scheme through the Retail Direct portal (https://rbiretaildirect.org.in).

For further details, please refer to RBI press release dated **October 23, 2026**, on RBI website www.rbi.org.in

"Don't get cheated by E-mails/SMSs/Calls promising you money."

France dodges repeat of riots, looting with tougher security

The government deployed some 70,000 security officials, including elite anti-terror forces

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France avoided a repeat of large-scale violence and looting that marred nationwide protests a week ago, suggesting the government's decision to boost police numbers and contain marches paid off.

About 110,000 people took part in a mostly peaceful demonstration confined to the edge of Paris on Saturday and another 300,000 turned out across the country, according to the Interior Ministry. The CGT union put the figure at 800,000.

Some scuffles broke out, especially on the margins and at the end of processions, with hundreds of masked individuals dressed in black taking on security personnel, who used tear gas and water cannon to disperse crowds.

While the level of violence toward the police was again high, Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said authorities were able to prevent the looting of shops and damage to buildings seen on Oct. 17. He blamed the clashes on the ultra left, which he said was seeking to "start and finish the uprising."

"All the warning signs were there so that we put in a place a significant presence," he said late on Saturday. "We will of course remain fully focused in the days and weeks ahead to face up to this threat, because it is a threat."

A total of 1,314 people had been arrested by Sunday morning, after a "calm night," the Interior Ministry said in a statement, about half the number compared with last weekend.

The government deployed some 70,000 security officials, including elite anti-terror forces, after being caught flat-footed a week ago, when nationwide demonstrations drew more than half a million people and descended into violence and looting.

Rioters attacked public buildings and broke into stores across the country, including in the capital, as well as fighting with police and setting fire to cars. French President Emmanuel Macron, the target of much of the anger, on Thursday acknowledged "planning failings and elements of surprise."

Soldiers were brought in to guard buildings, and helicopters and armoured vehicles were made available

For the latest protests, soldiers were brought in to guard sensitive buildings, and helicopters and armored vehicles known as Centaurs were made available on Saturday. Some cities banned protests and extended curfews.

Museums including Paris's Louvre were closed, while many shops were boarded up. A football match between Paris Saint-Germain and Olympique Lyonnais in Paris was postponed.

The protest movement began last month with high schoolers blockading establishments, calling for more teachers, repairs to buildings and an end to Parcoursup, a computerized college admissions system.

Nathanaël Combary, of the Renouveau Lycéen high school union, which is due to meet with Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu on Monday, said students were ready to continue demonstrating in the absence of concrete measures.

"The period of dialogue has lasted long enough," he told Sunday newspaper La Tribune Dimanche. "We now expect action."

One site has already called for another round of protests on Oct. 31, while labor unions are calling for a major day of strikes and protests on Nov. 5. The CGT pledged to expand the movement until its demands are met.

"The anger is immense, and our determination is even greater," the CGT said in a statement. "The government and employers must urgently respond to our social demands."

Backed by a disparate group of social media figures, students, unions and left-wing parties, Saturday's demonstrations were framed as an "Acte II," or second round, of the movement, which still has majority support in polls.

An Ipsos-BVA-Cési École d'ingénieurs survey for Le Parisien published on Saturday showed that while far-right candidate Marine Le Pen is still firmly in the lead ahead of next April's presidential election, the far-left France Unbowed leader, Jean-Luc Mélenchon, has also received a boost from the unrest and stands in second place, ahead of various centrist competitors. The poll of 1,500 adults was taken online on Oct. 21 and Oct. 22.

Mélenchon has been blamed by political rivals for stoking tensions, while he has accused the police of violence and called on Macron to give in to the movement's demands or risk having to do so in much more hazardous conditions.

The unrest has come amid concerns about France's public finances that has pushed a closely watched gauge of bond risk to levels last seen during the euro-area debt crisis.

The bloc's second-biggest economy dodged a downgrade at Moody's Ratings late on Friday, but the company warned that the widespread protests "could constrain fiscal consolidation efforts."

Preliminary gross domestic product data for the quarter through Sept. 30 is due on Friday. Analysts expect expansion of just 0.1% after zero growth in the previous quarter, adding to the fiscal challenge faced by the government.

Protests continued elsewhere in Europe over the weekend too. About 100 people were arrested in Barcelona while thousands marched in cities across Italy amid a heavy police presence, with scattered clashes reported. Albania's capital of Tirana continued to be rocked by demonstrations against its prime minister.

Protesters burned containers, vandalized shops, and threw stones at police in the area around Catalunya Square in central Barcelona. About one-quarter of those detained were minors, Nuria Parlon, the Catalan head of security, and Jaime Collboni, mayor of Spain's second largest city, said at a joint press conference.



The unrest has come amid concerns about France's public finances. AFP



A general view of the highway leading to the King Khalid International Airport In Riyadh, Saudi Arabia. REUTERS

Riyadh airport resumes ops amid Houthi attacks

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Yemen's Houthis launched wide-ranging strikes across swathes of southern Saudi Arabia on Sunday, as the kingdom announced the partial reopening of Riyadh international airport despite repeated attacks by the group.

Alerts warning of possible attacks were activated across the kingdom's south throughout the day, with the Saudi-led military coalition fighting the Houthis saying at least 10 ballistic missiles were intercepted.

Saudi Arabia, which leads a military coalition fighting the Iran-backed Houthis, has faced a barrage of strikes from the group in recent weeks.

The fighting erupted after a years-long truce between the Houthis and Yemen's Riyadh-backed government fell apart.

"The bombardment has been very heavy since this morning—may God keep us safe. Everything is shaking because of the explosions," one resident in Khamis Mushait told *AFP* Sunday on condition of anonymity.

The Saudi-led coalition said it intercepted a Houthi ballistic missile targeting the capital

Dozens of flights departed King Khalid International Airport early on Sunday to destinations including London, Dubai and Beijing, according to the airport's website.

Local carriers Saudia and Flynas operated flights, while international airlines including Air India and Emirates were also on the schedule. Most global carriers still have a suspension in place, meaning air traffic into and out of Riyadh is still heavily limited.

The airport, which suspended operations following Houthi attacks on Oct. 10-11 that killed more than a dozen people and injured hundreds, is operating at least two of its five terminals. Terminal 3, which sustained damages in the strikes this month, remains non-operational.

Houthi military spokesman Yahya Saree warned that Riyadh airport was still "unsafe" and a "military target". "The Yemeni Armed Forces warn all international, regional and local airlines—as well as staff and travellers—against using King Khalid Airport in Riyadh, as it is unsafe and serves as a military target for our forces," he said.

"The Saudi regime shall bear the consequences of any operations at the airport."

As the airport prepared to open, residents reported receiving alert messages for a "hostile aerial threat" urging them to stay in a safe place.

The warning came as the Saudi-led coalition fighting the Houthis said it had downed a ballistic missile launched by the group towards the capital, as well as two drones in the capital area. "Air defences intercepted and destroyed a ballistic missile launched by the terrorist Houthi militia toward Riyadh," the coalition posted on X.

Later Sunday morning, the coalition said its forces intercepted a cruise missile fired by the Houthis at the kingdom's southern city of Khamis Mushait. Attacks appeared to target areas across the south, with warnings also issued for Abha city along with areas in Taif, Namas and Jazan.

The attacks came after the Houthi fighters said that—in the space of 24 hours—they targeted three Saudi airports, including in Riyadh, energy installations, a pipeline and an air base.

The Saudi civil defence agency said it had also responded to falling debris in the Mecca and Medina regions on Saturday after intercepting two Houthi missiles. The Houthis denied targeting the cities, the two holiest in Islam, calling the Saudi claim a "huge lie". The Houthis also fired at the southern Yemeni city of Aden, the interim seat of the Saudi-backed government, saying they targeted a naval base and military camp overseen by Saudi forces.

The flare-up in Yemen, with the Houthis taking control of the entire Red Sea coast in a lightning offensive last month, has further destabilised the region and disrupted oil markets.

Bloomberg *contributed to this story.*

Trump prepares for Iran escalation after US, Israeli polls

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A Middle East war that US President Donald Trump said would be over in a matter of weeks now looks set to escalate as it enters its ninth month.

Trump has repeatedly hinted that his forces in the Mideast would resume strikes on Iran after the US midterm elections on 3 November. The president has already sent a third aircraft carrier strike group and 10,000 additional sailors and Marines toward the Persian Gulf to give US commanders more options if he restarts hostilities.

This week, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth also made an unannounced stop in Israel —which launched the war against Iran alongside the US —where he met with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu just days ahead of the Israeli leader's sensitive reelection bid. Staffing at Mideast bases, which have been hit hard by Iranian counterstrikes, has reportedly been reduced.

The US State Department this week ordered the departure of some diplomats and families in Saudi Arabia, following the Iran-backed Houthis expanding the conflict into Saudi Arabia.

Against that backdrop, Iran is now bracing for a fresh US bombing campaign around the midterms and is preparing to retaliate across the Middle East, including against Israel and the United Arab Emirates, according to a person familiar with Tehran's thinking.

The period between the US election and when the new Congress takes office in early January will be the most difficult period, and the only way out of the current conflict is a deal that allows both sides to claim a win, this person said, declining to be named because they weren't authorized to speak publicly.



Iran is now bracing for a fresh US bombing campaign. REUTERS

Some Gulf-state officials have a high degree of confidence that violence will resume, and said they fear it could be worse than before the pause, according to a person familiar with the UAE government's thinking.

"We've knocked the hell out of them—and we may do it a little bit further," Trump told reporters Thursday, echoing that sentiment.

Meanwhile, Iran is attacking more ships in or near the Strait of Hormuz—and causing more severe damage—than earlier in the conflict at it deploys guided missiles rather than attack drones, according to shipping and maritime security officials.

The US State Department this week ordered the departure of some diplomats and families in Saudi Arabia

"All indications point to a resumption of war and a major bombing campaign, although the timing remains uncertain," said Asli Ayduntaşbaş, an expert on the Middle East at the Brookings Institution.

Renewed fighting could help Netanyahu force political rivals into a national unity government, while strikes could help Trump project a "dramatic show of force to project strength at home," according to International Crisis Group Mideast expert Ali Vaez.

"Both Trump and Netanyahu may see war with Iran as a political escape hatch," Vaez said. "But both risk discovering that a war intended to rescue their political fortunes could end up burying them."

The US and Israeli elections are complicating efforts to stop the march toward war, and other nations must step up efforts to reach a deal before it's too late, a senior European diplomat said.

The heated Israeli election —the first since the Hamas attacks in 2023 that sparked Netanyahu's wars in Gaza and Lebanon—is Tuesday. If Netanyahu loses the election, his chief rival, Gadi Eisenkot, may not be as eager to begin his term restarting the Iran war.

In recent months, the White House has also added to a punishing naval blockade of Iranian ports by ramping up economic sanctions targeting Tehran's remaining trade partners. While the sanctions campaign has underwhelmed experts, the naval blockade continues to have a real impact, though growing pressure may push Iran to strike out across the Gulf.

Recent attempts to wind down the war through diplomatic talks have failed. But Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi made a plea this week to return to diplomatic negotiations.

The Saudi airline that launched right in the middle of a war

Benjamin Katz & Stephen Kalin

The day after a missile hit the airport where Riyadh Air's offices are based, the British boss of Saudi Arabia's new airline wanted to soothe staff fears.

"We would never operate a flight or have people work in a building if we were not confident in its safety," Chief Executive Tony Douglas wrote in a companywide note earlier this month. The airline's headquarters remained "open for business as usual," he said, despite an attack just a couple of miles away that destroyed an aircraft and killed three people, including a pilot at its sister airline.

Within 24 hours, the Houthi militia in neighboring Yemen behind that strike launched a fresh missile barrage on the capital, killing over a dozen people at the same airport, collapsing part of the terminal building and leaving hundreds more injured.

The CEO's next message to staff told most to stay home the following day, according to emails reviewed by *The Wall Street Journal*.

The escalating conflict with the Houthis, who have declared commercial aviation a target, has upended Saudi Arabia's airline industry and the operations of global carriers that increasingly rely on its airspace for transit.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The violence has particularly dampened the fortunes of Riyadh Air—which started commercial flights this summer, aiming to be a key part of the kingdom's long-term economic ambitions. The airline has repeatedly diverted flights and canceled others at the last minute. Some have been placed in holding patterns for as long as two hours while waiting out active threats, tracking data shows.

Just months after getting off the ground, the airline has evacuated all aircraft from its home base and has halted almost all flying over the past two weeks.

The handful of special flights the airline operated in recent days landed either in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, or at a small airport 200 miles from Riyadh, with passengers ferried on an hourslong ground journey to the capital.

A spokesman for Riyadh Air didn't respond to requests for comment.

This year was meant to see the launch of a key pillar in Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's ambition for his economy: a high-end airline to transport wealthy tourists. It was also designed to help the country catch up with rivals in the United Arab Emirates and Qatar, whose airlines have become dominating forces in global air travel over the past three decades, thanks in part to their convenient location between Europe and Asia.



The escalating conflict has particularly dampened the fortunes of Riyadh Air. REUTERS

It is a strategy Riyadh Air's sister carrier, Saudia, hasn't pursued, instead focusing its operations on the massive demand from workers in the kingdom's oil industry and from those traveling there for pilgrimage. Its operations have likewise been upended by Houthi attacks, which on Oct. 8 killed one of its pilots and destroyed an Airbus A320 aircraft.

The violence isn't only rattling Saudi Arabia's aviation dream, but also putting the likes of Emirates, the world's biggest long-haul carrier, under pressure as Gulf airlines battle to overcome flight restrictions and anxieties about their flights' proximity to the war in Iran.

This summer, Riyadh Air's CEO struck an optimistic tone, despite having delayed a soft launch set for March as missiles crisscrossed the region. Douglas, in an interview in London in June, said getting new seats for his aircraft in time had been more of a headache than the conflict playing out across the Middle East.

Four months later, with the airline's primary airport facing a prolonged closure, Riyadh Air staff have instead been volunteering at hospitals where victims of the airport strikes were treated.

Its newest aircraft, delivered by Boeing last week, had to be redirected to Jeddah. That came days after the airline withdrew from the capital the last of its Boeing 787 Dreamliners—each valued at more than $130 million—after it was grounded following light damage from a missile strike.

Prospects for the rest of the year are looking grim, too, as Iranian officials have told mediators Tehran would respond to any renewed U.S.-Israel attacks with strikes aimed at civilian targets, including airports. The airline is also facing a renewal of its war-risk insurance policy next month, the Journal has reported.

The carrier is set to restart in force on Sunday, with only four flights listed on its website as canceled—compared with over 30 scrapped each day since the airport closure on Oct. 10.

The return to semiregular flying would come with a major caveat: Riyadh Air won't be flying to Riyadh. Instead, the airline is using a route it tested earlier in the week, sending aircraft from places such as London, Islamabad and Cairo to an airport in Al Qassim province, according to the carrier's website. From there it is a free 4 -hour bus journey to the Saudi capital.

Complimentary water, juice and snacks are provided.

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

$4.2 bn
THE AMOUNT Audi plans to invest in its first US vehicle assembly plant near Macon,Georgia, to produce 200,000 SUVs annually and create about 4,500 jobs.

4,480
THE NET number of employees Infosys added in the Q2FY27, marking a recovery in headcount after a decline in the previous quarter.

₹2,872 cr
THE VALUE of turnkey orders KEC International secured from Power Grid Corporation of India for the design, supply, and installation transmission lines.

₹317.86 cr
THE CROP insurance payouts released by the Madhya Pradesh government to farmers for crop losses during the rabi season 2025-26.

₹779 cr
THE AMOUNT electric motorcycle maker Ultraviolette Automotive plans to invest in a new manufacturing facility in Hosur, Tamil Nadu.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Five companies to launch IPOs this week



The companies are expected to launch plans by 5 November. ISTOCKPHOTO

Five companies, including EAAA India Alternatives, SFC Environmental Technologies, and M K Sons Fine Jewels, are set to launch their initial public offerings (IPOs) next week, seeking to raise close to ₹2,600 crore from the primary market.

BLS Polymers and Bombay Coated and Special Steels would also float their maiden public offerings during the week.

Separately, several other companies, including Gujarat Victory Forging, Milestone Gears, Avaada Electro, Swara Baby Products, Integris Medtech and AGS Health, are in the pipeline for IPO, according to merchant bankers.

These companies are expected to announce price band declarations and launch plans by 5 November, ahead of the extended Diwali holiday period in Gujarat, where markets and business activity are likely to be affected by the post-Diwali observance of Labh Pancham from 6 to 15 November, they added.

The upcoming issues follow a busy month for the primary market, which saw Jio Platforms launch the country's biggest-ever public issue worth ₹30,213 crore. PTI

NMDC scouts for mining assets

From South America in the west to Australia in the east, state-owned iron ore giant National Mineral Development Corporation Ltd (NMDC) is scouting mining assets, including critical minerals, in four continents to meet the future needs of industries such as automotive, renewable energy, electronics, and steel, according to persons from the industry aware of the matter.

NMDC has set a goal to earn at least 20% of revenues from sale of minerals other than the key steel making raw material. The public sector undertaking is exploring lithium, copper, cobalt and rare earth blocks in Chile (South America), Australia, Africa, Brazil and parts of Asia. PTI

Carlsberg revenue slips to ₹8,708.8 cr

Initial public offering-bound brewer Carlsberg India has reported a 2.2% decline in its revenue to ₹8,708.8 crore for financial year (FY) 26; however, its profit rose 22%to ₹534.51 crore.

The company's total income, including other income, declined 2.25% to ₹8,814.96 crore in the financial year ended March 2026, according to financial data accessed through business intelligence platform Tofler.

Carlsberg India Ltd, part of Danish brewing major Carlsberg Group, had reported revenue from operations of ₹8,906.50 crore and a profit of ₹437.94 crore in FY25. Carlsberg India's royalty paid to its parent entity was up 13.23% to ₹90.01 crore in FY26. PTI



The case relates to eight GST refund claims totalling ₹45,92,528 by Singapore Airlines. ISTOCKPHOTO

GSTAT allows GST refund on air tickets

Goods and Services Tax (GST) paid on cancelled airline tickets can be claimed as a refund if the airline has returned both the fare and GST to the passengers and has supporting documents to prove it, a GST Appellate Tribunal has ruled.

Ruling in the case of Singapore Airlines Ltd v/s Kochi Commissioner of Central Goods and Services Tax & CE, Kochi, Ernakulam bench of GST Appellate Tribunal (GSTAT) has decided that there is "sufficient evidence" to ensure that the refund of cancelled tickets has reached the respective passengers directly and there is "no passing" of the incidence of tax.

The GSTAT directed the revenue department to process the refund claim of the airline within two weeks and make payment along with interest.

The case relates to eight GST refund claims totalling ₹45,92,528 by Singapore Airlines for the period between October 2019 and March 2021. During the period, owing to COVID-19, the airline had to cancel flights and returned fares and GST to passengers.

However, it could not adjust the credit notes against output tax. PTI



PTI

12-year journey of Mann Ki Baat a 'pilgrimage': Modi

Modi said those who live for society and the nation are like a pilgrimage site in themselves

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NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday termed the 12-year journey of his monthly radio broadcast 'Mann Ki Baat' a "pilgrimage", describing it as an opportunity to closely understand the efforts of citizens and pay tribute to their contributions.

In the 139th edition of the programme, Modi also said that through the radio address, he, in a way, worships the collective power (Lokshakti) of the nation and it gives him the opportunity to connect with every family in the country.

"Welcome once again to Mann Ki Baat. Twelve years ago today, on the auspicious occasion of Vijayadashami, we began Mann Ki Baat. Since then, our journey has been continuing without interruption. You are both fellow travellers and guides on this journey," he said.

The prime minister said for him, Mann Ki Baat has been a "blessed occasion" to sing the praises of the hard work, valour, commitment, dedication, and spirit of service of the common people of the country.

"There has been an ancient tradition of pilgrimage in our country. For me, Mann Ki Baat is no less than a pilgrimage to closely learn about the efforts of the people of the country and to bow down to their contributions," he said.

Modi said those who live for society and the nation are like a pilgrimage site in themselves.

In these 12 years, he said, many such people have come forward from every corner of the country whose extraordinary work usually misses the attention of society.

"Mann Ki Baat has worked to bring countless such inspiring stories before all of you.

Through this programme, I, in a way, worship the collective power of the nation. It gives me the opportunity to connect with every family in the country," he said. The prime minister said he receives hundreds of messages in which people share that after listening to Mann Ki Baat, they felt as if he was sitting among them as a member of their family, conversing with them. "For me, this intimacy and affection from all of you listeners is an invaluable asset," he said.

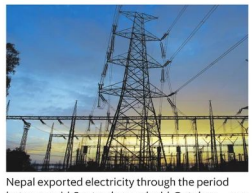
Isro to have four launch pads by '29

Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro) Chairman V. Narayanan has said that India will expand its space operations significantly with four functional launch pads by 2029.

He outlined the agency's road map, which includes a 2,000-acre dedicated Small Satellite Launch Vehicle complex at Kulasekarapattinam in Thoothukudi district to meet the global demand for satellite deployment.

Clarifying that the national space agency will not be privatized, Narayanan emphasized that partnering with private firms was essential to meet surging global and domestic demands for thousands of satellites.

"To handle this expanding ecosystem, Isro will handhold startups and private enterprises, transferring technological expertise to foster economic growth and generate thousands of high-tech jobs," he added. PTI



Nepal exported electricity through the period between mid-September and mid-October. MINT

India gets $39-mn power from Nepal

Nepal exported electricity worth over $39 million to India between mid-September and mid-October, an official said on Sunday. According to Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) Executive Director Dirghayu Kumar Shrestha, electricity exports recovered during the period after being briefly disrupted by the flash floods in August.

"Nepal exported electricity worth approximately Nepalese rupees 5.92 billion (about $39 million) to India from mid-September to mid-October," Shrestha was quoted as saying by *The Himalayan Times* newspaper.

Nearly two-thirds of the cross-border electricity supply to India was exported under bilateral agreements, he added.

On Friday, Nepal resumed exporting 40 megawatts of electricity to Bangladesh through India's transmission network. PTI

AI marks inflection point: HCL CEO

As artificial intelligence reshapes the technology industry, HCL Technologies (HCLTech) chief executive officer and managing director C Vijayakumar has said the sector has reached another "inflection point" with artificial intelligence (AI), and that the future belongs not necessarily to the largest, but those willing to keep reinventing themselves. He made the remarks in a LinkedIn post marking 10 years since he took charge of the IT services major.

Vijayakumar described a decade as a long time in the technology industry, during which industries have been reinvented, business models disrupted, and the boundaries of what is possible have shifted repeatedly.

Looking ahead, he tied the company's path directly to the AI moment. "Today as AI reshapes our industry, we are once again at an inflection point," he wrote. PTI

Pre-sales of Godrej Prop may rise 22%

Realty firm Godrej Properties' sales bookings is expected to rise 22% this fiscal to a record ₹41,500 crore, beating annual guidance on strong demand for its housing properties, according to its chairperson Pirojsha Godrej.

In an interview with *PTI*, Pirojsha Godrej noted that consumer demand has been "quite strong" in the company's new as well as ongoing residential projects across all markets where it has a presence. Even for the overall real estate market, he said the housing demand has "held up" and is "quite steady" despite the West Asia crisis causing global economic uncertainties. Pirojsha said the company was on track to meet annual guidance or exceed it across all key metrics, including sales bookings, launches, collection of funds from customers, deliveries of projects and land acquisition. Godrej Properties has completed projects spanning more than 80 million sq. ft since 2018. PTI

'Platform deals on the rise in pharma and healthcare'

Jessica Jani & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

The pharmaceutical and healthcare sectors are entering a new wave of consolidation, with private equity (PE) firms and strategic buyers increasingly looking to build larger, scaled-up businesses through acquisitions and platform building. Subhakanta Bal, managing director and head of healthcare and consumer (India) at global financial advisory group Rothschild & Co., told *Mint* in an interview.

"If you think about private equity, especially the larger funds, I think the concept around platform building makes a lot of sense for several reasons," said Bal. First off is the scale benefit. Second, "scope to eke out efficiencies on procurement, supply chain, and overheads," he said. There is also the ability to invest in capability, including technology, and lastly, "from an exit perspective, especially for public markets, where scale has its own premium or attractiveness".

The trend is expected to support more dealmaking across domestic branded medicines and healthcare services. Local pharma companies are likely to be active overseas, too, pursuing speciality products, new markets and attractively valued acquisition targets.



Subhakanta Bal, MD and head of healthcare and consumer (India) at Rothschild & Co.

ChrysCapital completed the acquisition of a 70.68% stake in Novartis India in July from the parent company, Novartis AG, gaining access to strong legacy brands such as Voveran, Calcium Sandoz, and Tegrital for the domestic market. Since then, it has been expanding its portfolio through tie-ups and brand buyouts from MNCs, such as the acquisition of Indian trademarks for Pfizer's hypertension brand 'Minipress'.

KKR is building a scaled, multi-speciality hospital platform in India. In August, it agreed to acquire the India hospital business of Swedish healthcare provider Medicover AB in a deal valued at roughly $1.4 billion. This adds to existing assets including Kerala-based Baby Memorial Hospital, acquired in 2024, and oncology chain Healthcare Global Enterprises (HCG). The private equity firm has been expanding Baby Memorial Hospital through regional acquisitions, such as the 2025 acquisition of Kozhikode-based Meitra Hospital. In April this year, it was reported that the firm had agreed to buy a 60% stake in Hyderabad-based Star Hospitals.

It is not just PEs driving the consolidation in India. "One of the big developments in the last five years relative to pre-covid has been a lot more interest from local strategics to execute local acquisitions and participate in domestic consolidation, and that has been true in both pharma as well as healthcare services," said Bal.

Transactions including Torrent Pharmaceuticals' acquisition of JB Chemicals and Mankind Pharma's acquisition of BSV also reflect the appetite for consolidation.

"We think that we will continue to see a lot of traction from private equity wanting to play in the domestic branded formulations segment, given the fragmentation that exists in the segment...," said Bal.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

IndiGo, Air India clear runway for shift to Navi Mumbai airport

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After weeks of holding out against shifting flights from Mumbai to Navi Mumbai, IndiGo and the Air India Group have become the first carriers to announce plans to move some operations to the new airport, paving the way for the redevelopment of Terminal 1 (T1) at the city's existing airport.

Together, they will shift 133 weekly international departures to the new airport about 50 km away by July, marking a breakthrough in a standoff with operator Adani Airport Holdings Ltd, according to a person familiar with the discussions.

The standoff, which saw airlines resist the plan to shift and question capacity curbs at Terminal 2 (T2), prompted the civil aviation ministry's intervention and a string of exchanges between the airport operator and carriers.

IndiGo will shift 84 weekly departures, while Air India Group—Air India and Air India Express—will move a total of 49, said a person familiar with the discussions. The earmarked services will be temporarily withdrawn from Mumbai, said the person cited above.

In separate announcements on Sunday, IndiGo said it would progressively transfer 12 daily international departures to Navi Mumbai between February and July 2027. Air India's low-cost arm Air India Express plans to begin four daily domestic flights in December, followed by a phased transfer of services to West Asian destinations from January.



IndiGo has announced shifting 84 weekly departures. MINT

Together, these two airlines are likely to handle nearly 3 million passengers from the Navi Mumbai airport, accounting for about 60% of the traffic affected by the proposed transition, the person said.

The airports at both Mumbai and Navi Mumbai are managed by Adani Airport Holdings.

Adani had proposed to temporarily discontinue 265 of the 770 weekly international departure slots at T2 from 25 October. The plan also involved shifting domestic operations from T1 to T2, necessitating capacity curbs affecting about 5 million passengers annually. The proposed international slot cuts covered 46 airlines, including IndiGo, which was asked to discontinue 74 of its 224 weekly international departures; Air India, 33 of 100; and Air India Express, seven of 21.

In a joint statement with Adani Airport, IndiGo said it would move 12 daily international departures from Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport to Navi Mumbai International Airport. The destinations include Bahrain, Riyadh, Dammam, Jeddah, Madinah, Kuwait, Ras Al Khaimah, Fujairah, Muscat, Dhaka and Jakarta.

IndiGo will also launch a daily service to Kathmandu, taking its global network at Navi Mumbai to 12 cities between February and July. While the 12 daily departures will be transferred across 11 existing destinations, Kathmandu will be additional destination served by a new daily flight.

"IndiGo will also shift the domestic connectivity needed to feed these international flights," it said, adding that the relocation will free up capacity at Mumbai airport for planned international expansion across Asia, Africa and Europe in 2027.

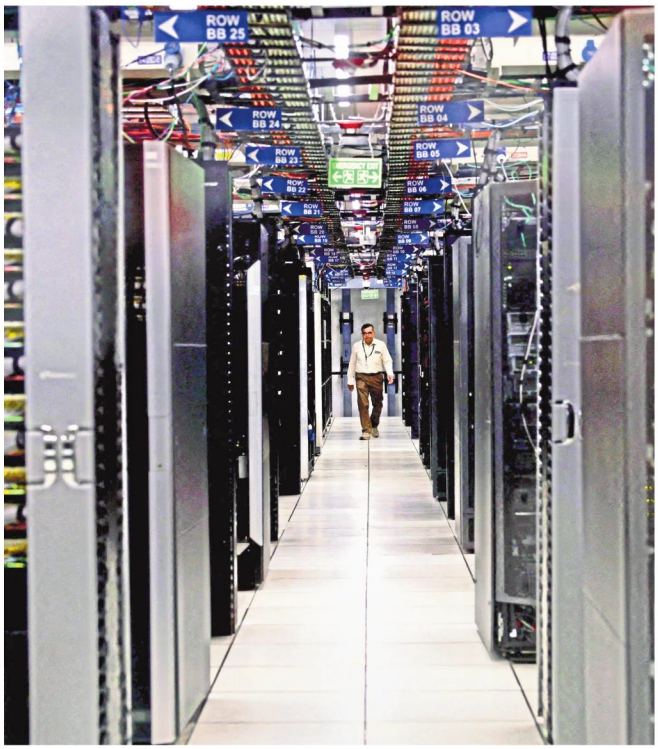
Air India Group said it will "commence the phased transition of some of its West Asia services to Navi Mumbai International Airport, with Air India Express operating four daily domestic flights from December 2026 and planned services to Kuwait and existing services to Oman from January 2027."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

FULL STACK: INSIDE THE $100 BILLION AI BET ON INDIA

Tech giants are pouring vast sums into AI-ready data centres across the country. Can that infrastructure help India become a creator of AI models?

Shelley Singh
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(Clockwise from left) AI data centres need GPUs that consume 100–250 kW of power per rack to run GPT and AI models; the construction site of Google's AI and data centre hub at Tarluvada village near Visakhapatnam; Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay and Singapore deputy prime minister Gan Kim Yong during the inauguration earlier in October of CapitaLand Data Centre Chennai 01. REUTERS & AFP & PTI

When OpenAI launched ChatGPT in November 2022, the artificial intelligence (AI) model took the world by storm. Since then a slew of other companies have launched their own AI models, including Anthropic with Claude, Google with Gemini, and xAI with Grok. And that has led users to lean on AI to search, learn and work.

Indians have been at the forefront in adopting AI. ChatGPT alone has more than 100 million users in India, or around 10% of its global user base. Indeed, government thinktank Niti Aayog estimates that AI adoption could unlock approximately $1 trillion in economic value for India by 2035.

But while Indians are among the world's biggest AI users, much of the computing infrastructure powering this digital activity sits outside the country. India is among the world's largest consumers of digital services, but a relatively small host of the computing power that sustains them. Specifically, the country generates nearly 20% of the world's data but accounts for just 3% of global data-centre capacity, according to Boston Consulting Group (BCG).

That is beginning to change gradually. From Visakhapatnam to Mumbai, Hyderabad and Chennai, a construction boom is gathering momentum. More than $100 billion in investments have been committed across hyperscalers, data-centre operators and Indian conglomerates.

In August, Microsoft commissioned a data centre the size of two Eden Garden cricket stadiums in Hyderabad. Around 600km away in Visakhapatnam, Google is building its AI hub. Another hyperscaler, Amazon Web Services (AWS), is expanding its data centre capacity across Mumbai and Hyderabad.

Local companies are also building campuses designed to answer AI prompts. The expansion is moving beyond traditional technology centres, with projects emerging in places such as Patna and Bodh Gaya.

India's data-centre capacity, estimated at 1.5GW in 2025, could reach 6–8GW by 2030 and 12–14GW by 2035, according to BCG. The operational data-centre capacity has already expanded from about 375MW in 2020 to nearly 1.8GW by the first half of 2026, according to reality services firm Cushman & Wakefield.

"India's objective is to move from being the world's largest user of digital services to owning the compute layer beneath them," says Sudhanshu Chawla, managing director and partner, BCG. The consultancy expects capacity to grow at an annual rate of 30–40% through the end of the decade and generate $140–200 billion in economic output.

The Reserve Bank of India mandates that all financial data be hosted locally and the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act mandates any data related to identity, location tracking, and online user logs be stored in India, laying the ground for the growth of local centres.

Data centres have been granted infrastructure status, improving access to long-term institutional financing. Union budget 2026-27 also introduced a tax holiday extending to 2047 for eligible foreign cloud providers using notified Indian data-centre infrastructure to serve global customers.

These sops are designed to attract not just capital but the computing workloads that could establish India as an international digital infrastructure hub. Moreover, says Union minister of state for science and technology Jitendra Singh, the growth in data centres could generate "nearly one lakh specialized engineering jobs".

> The government has introduced a tax holiday up to 2047 for eligible foreign cloud providers to serve global customers.

But will India merely become a vast hosting location for AI technologies developed elsewhere, or can the infrastructure help it build an AI industry of its own? And should it be trying to match the leaders or focus on harnessing AI to tackle the country's unique and myriad challenges?

PLAYING CATCHUP

For decades, India's technology advantage rested largely on software services and a vast pool of engineering talent. The emerging AI economy is changing that equation. Developing and deploying AI increasingly requires access to enormous computing resources, sophisticated chips, reliable power and high-speed networks. AI data centres carry that processing power.

To be sure, data centres themselves are not new. They have been around for decades. Legacy data centres host email, payroll, business software like ERP, websites, banking operations, securities transactions and so on. But these traditional data centres cannot run AI workloads and hence the need for AI data centres.

Explaining the difference, Sridhar Pinnapureddy, founder and chief executive of Hyderabad-based CtrlS Datacenters, says legacy data centres require 5–10kW of power per rack, and use CPU (central processing unit) chips. AI processing, in comparison, is far more compute-intensive and needs graphics processing units (GPUs) that consume 100–250 kW of power per rack to run GPT models, AI models, autonomous cars, improve drug discovery, financial modelling and so on.

The government's IndiaAI Mission has onboarded more than 40,000 GPUs, expanding access to subsidized computing resources. But India's AI processing capacity remains small compared with the infrastructure available to leading global laboratories. For instance, Harvard University alone has over 1,000 GPUs. The US has around 10 million GPUs, while China's GPU density is more than 10 times that of India.

India's data-centre boom could help narrow that gap. For start-ups, universities and enterprises, local computing infrastructure can reduce dependence on overseas facilities, reduce latency, improve access to computing resources and make some AI applications cheaper and faster to operate.

The new facilities that are coming up are not simply larger versions of traditional server farms; they are being engineered to support a much wider range of computing-intensive applications. "As AI moves from pilots to real world inferencing and production deployments, companies need infrastructure that brings compute, data and users closer together while meeting data residency and compliance requirements," says Manoj Paul, managing director, India, at Equinix, a California-based data-centre and interconnection services company.

"AI is fundamentally changing how data centres are designed and operated," says Pinnapureddy. CtrlS is designing facilities capable of supporting rack densities of up to 250 kW. CapitaLand's Navi Mumbai facility has also been designed for high-density AI computing.

Google expects its Visakhapatnam campus to accommodate GPUs, its proprietary TPUs, conventional CPUs and networking equipment, reflecting the different requirements of AI training, inference and everyday cloud services. "It's really the foundational layer of the AI economy that is coming up in India. It will help India move from AI pilots to population level impact," says Alexander Smith, principal, global infrastructure and energy, Asia Pacific, Google.

WHO'S DOING WHAT

Google's upcoming AI hub in Visakhapatnam is part of a $15 billion investment announced by the company in 2025. Unlike its existing cloud regions in Mumbai and Delhi, which operate with domestic partners, Visakhapatnam will be Google's first fully owned and operated data-centre facility in India.

Microsoft has committed $20.5 billion, its largest investment anywhere in Asia to build AI capabilities across India. While AWS plans to invest over $21 billion into AI and cloud facilities between 2026 and 2030.

The projects will bring together subsea connectivity, advanced computing infrastructure and AI capabilities. "What Visakhapatnam is doing in this project is starting to build a third subsea gateway for India, which will offer the country additional resiliency and connectivity," says Smith.

The new gateway will connect to terrestrial fibre networks reaching metros and smaller cities. It will also strengthen India's connections with Southeast Asia, Australia and other international markets. Designed primarily to meet Indian demand, Visakhapatnam will become an important regional node in Google's global network.

Microsoft's newest cloud region, India South Central, in Hyderabad, will serve domestic customers while functioning as a strategic hub for Asia and the Global South. Its current customers include the Adani Group, Bajaj Finserv, HDFC Bank and PB Pay.

Pointing to the shift from digital public infrastructure to AI, Puneet Chandok, president, Microsoft India and South Asia, says, "India built the rails (UPI, Aadhaar) for a billion people to transact; we are now helping build the rails for them to work and create with AI."

AWS' $21 billion India AI investment announced in July is on top of the more than $9 billion invested since establishing its first Indian cloud region in Mumbai in 2016.

"By giving Indian organizations local access to custom AI chips, and managed AI services, our data centres lower the barrier for startups, enterprises and governments to build and scale AI," says Anurag Khilnani, director, data centre delivery, APAC, AWS. Users include HDFC Securities, Physics Wallah, Care Health Insurance, and DigiLocker.

Indian operators are investing aggressively, too. Hyderabad-based CtrlS Datacenters operates 18 facilities across nine markets and is developing new capacity in Mumbai and Hyderabad. It has also inaugurated a ₹400-crore facility in Patna and announced plans for a ₹10,000-crore, 150MW AI data centre in Bodh Gaya.

CapitaLand India Trust India (CLINT) has committed more than ₹5,000 crore to three data centres in Navi Mumbai, Hyderabad and Chennai, with approximately 200MW of power capacity. The Navi Mumbai tower was handed over to an unidentified global hyperscaler in July, while the second has been pre-leased. "We are in active leasing discussions with both global and domestic customers," says Gauri Shankar Nagabhushanam, CEO, CLINT.

Equinix has invested more than $365 million in India and operates five facilities across Mumbai and Chennai.

The new data centres are eyeing business from the domestic market. Banks, insurance companies, e-commerce platforms, hospital chains, startups and government agencies are generating vast quantities of data and increasingly deploying AI-driven applications. These uses include AI-powered voice bots, fraud detection, reading medical images and data such as X-rays, ECGs, doing research and sales forecasts. "India will become a global node in Google's network and the global internet, more broadly," says Smith.

THE OPPORTUNITY

With a $100 billion investment, the scale of the data centre buildout is unprecedented. Yet the distinction between hosting AI and creating AI remains critical. A data centre owned by a global technology company may serve Indian customers while much of the underlying technology, intellectual property and commercial value remains overseas.

To capture more of that value, India will need to build on its expanding infrastructure with stronger domestic research, affordable access to indigenous models, specialized talent and commercially viable AI applications.

Currently, India lags way behind the US and China in developing frontier AI models. It has not yet produced a globally leading frontier model comparable to those developed by the largest American AI companies, including OpenAI, Anthropic, Google DeepMind, Microsoft Co-Pilot and China's DeepSeek. Training such models requires vast clusters of specialized chips, billions of dollars in investment and access to advanced research capabilities, all of which India currently lacks.

But the opportunity for India may lie less in trying to build large AI models and more in applying AI to tackle problems on a national scale, in areas such as healthcare, education, agriculture, manufacturing and public services.

Consider healthcare; Google has worked with Aravind Eye Hospital to

TURN TO PAGE 11

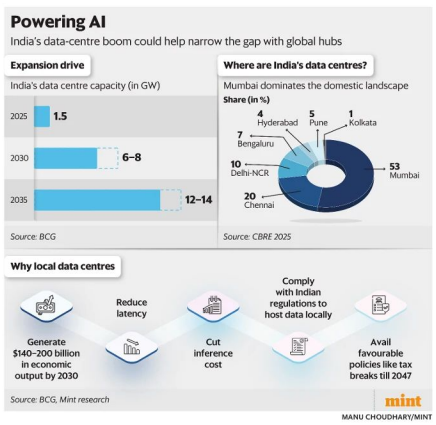
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mint KEY NUMBERS

~20%
India's share in the total amount of data generated globally, according to a study by the Boston Consulting Group.

3%
The nation's share in data-centre capacity worldwide, according to BCG. The US is the leader, accounting for more than 60%.

>40,000
Number of GPUs onboarded by the IndiaAI Mission. The US has around 10 million; China's density is over 10 times that of India.



Rising bond yields put gilt fund managers at a critical crossroads

Fund managers are divided on locking in yields or waiting for further rises amid rate hikes and high crude prices

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Global bond yields are rising, leaving Indian gilt fund investors to choose between locking in higher yields and waiting for a better entry point. The US 10-year Treasury yield is near 5%, up from 4% a year ago, while Brent crude has topped $110 a barrel amid West Asia supply concerns, stoking inflation risks. India's 10-year government bond yield hit 7.47% on 23 October, its highest in three-and-a-half years, up from 6.76% in mid-August and 6.54% a year ago. Rising US yields, crude prices and expectations of monetary tightening have added to the pressure.

Higher yields attract new investors but depress existing bond price, hurting debt funds. Gilt fund NAVs fell about 2.5% since mid-August (as of 21 October), leaving fund managers divided between buying gradually and waiting for yields to rise further.

The case for gilt funds

The case for investing rests on the view that yields are attractive and much of the expected monetary tightening is priced in. "Yields at close to 7.45-7.5% are a good entry point. But investors should enter in a staggered manner and not put the entire sum in at one go, as oil is rising and yields are elevated globally. We don't know where the top will be," said Puneet Pal, head of fixed income at PGIM India Mutual Fund.

Joydeep Sen, corporate trainer and author, said the gap between 10-year yield and the policy rate suggests further increases in bond yields could be limited. "Over the last 25 years, the average spread between the repo rate and the 10-year g-sec yield has been about one percentage point. Today, it is almost double that. So even if the RBI hikes further, the 10-year yield may not move up as much, since it is already in an elevated zone." Sen also favours staggered investments.

On 7 October, RBI raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.5% and shifted its stance to "calibrated tightening". Longer-duration portfolios are more exposed to rising yields because their bond prices are more sensitive to interest-rate changes. However, holding investments over a longer period can help offset short-term losses through interest income and reinvestment at higher yields.

"Staying invested for a period close to a fund's duration, typically over a 7-9 year horizon can help reduce the impact of volatility. When holding period is longer, the fund's NAV falls in the short term, but the fund reinvests its interest income and maturing bonds at higher yields, which makes up for the loss over time. So, the return ends up close to the yield at which you entered. And if yield levels normalize, you also stand to benefit from capital appreciation. Yield of close to 7.5% is a good level to lock-in for those with a long investment horizon," Ashish Chadha, a registered investment advisor, said.

Past returns give some support for long-term case. A *Mint* analysis of gilt funds since 2005 found that no holding period of five years or longer delivered a negative return. Minimum returns were 3.3% over seven years and 4.5% over 10 years. Average returns were at 7.2% to 7.8% across holding periods of one to 10 years. Maximum returns were 11.9% in seven years and 10.4% in 10.

> **Gilt funds have low credit risk but high interest-rate risk; cautious investors may prefer short-duration funds**

Nippon India Mutual Fund's Sushil Budhia, senior fund manager-fixed income, said much of the negative news is priced in. "With RBI changing its stance to calibrated tightening, we expect three more 25-bps-hikes, taking repo rate to 6.25%. A part of this rate hike cycle is built into the current 10-year yield. Yields may remain in a narrow corridor of 15-20 basis points and not move too much either way from here," he said.

Case for caution

Other fund managers expect yields to rise further before stabilising, potentially offering investors a better entry point. "Yields have gone up quickly. You may see a retracement if at all of 10-15 bps to 7.30%, but it may not sustain there. A lot of issues need to be sorted out before yields can come down meaningfully," said Shantanu Godambe, fund manager at DSP Mutual Fund.

Murthy Nagarajan, head of fixed income at Tata Asset Management, does not expect the 10-year yield to fall below 7.25% soon.

"The capex cycle in India is strong and rates are high globally. A foreign investor earning 5% in the US will not come here for 7.25-7.5%, if you factor in rupee depreciation of another 3%," Nagarajan said.

Currency-market volatility has also pushed firms that borrowed overseas towards domestic markets, tightening liquidity. Nagarajan expects RBI to raise repo rate to 6%, with inflation staying above 5% and the Eighth Pay Commission adding to demand. "It is better to be at short end and earn the 8% accrual available there," he said.

Bond supply is also a concern. Government borrowing, corporate debt issuance and state development loans are adding to the securities the market must absorb, while deposit mobilisation remains a challenge for banks.

"Issuance of state development loans (SDLs), corporate bond issuances, together with the central government borrowing, there is more supply than the market has demand for, which will add to the upward pressure on yields," Godambe said.

The government estimates market borrowing of ₹15.99 trillion for FY27.

Budhia, however, believes a moderation in credit growth can bring more demand back into the bond market. "Current credit growth of 17-18% could be temporary, reflecting higher working capital needs for supply-side and oil price-related issues. Mean reversion in credit growth to more manageable levels will bring back some demand into bonds."

For Godambe, investors should wait till the market absorbs more of the expected monetary tightening. "The rate hike cycle has just begun. Once we are 50 basis points further into it and people start wondering whether another 25 or 50 bps is coming, that is when you can start investing, as markets would have priced in a lot of the negativity by then. Now, it's a hope trade that the dollar and US yields will come down," he said.

What investors should do

Gilt funds carry negligible credit risk because they invest in government securities, but they remain exposed to interest-rate risk. Longer-duration funds can suffer larger short-term losses when yields rise.

A 50-bps rise in yields on a portfolio with a modified duration of six can translate into a nearly 3% negative impact. Modified duration measures a bond's sensitivity to interest-rate changes; the higher it is, the greater the potential price movement for a given change in yields.

The choice depends on investors' risk appetite and investment horizon. Gilt funds may suit those able to withstand near- to medium-term volatility and stay invested through interest-rate cycles. Those seeking greater stability should keep most of their debt allocation in shorter-duration funds, which are less sensitive to yield changes.

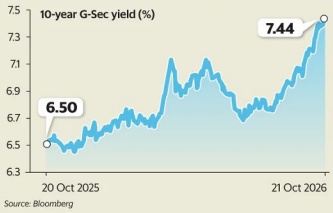
"Gilt funds should only be considered by investors who understand interest rate risk and can stomach near-to-medium-term volatility as there are still a lot of variables," said Surya Bhatia, financial adviser, Asset Managers, a financial consultancy.

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Gilt funds: should you invest?

Fund managers are divided, with some seeing current yield levels as an attractive opportunity to build positions gradually, while others recommend a more cautious approach.

India's 10-year government bond yields have surged amid the West Asia war, rising crude oil prices, interest rate hikes and mounting inflationary pressures



Source: Bloomberg



Rolling returns analysis of gilt funds shows volatility impact eases over longer holding periods



Note: Rolling returns calculated daily between 1 January 2005 and 21 October 2026; returns are annualized; regular plans considered

Source: Mint analysis; NAV data sourced from ACE MF

Fund managers have mixed views

- **Some say** invest in staggered manner; yields factor in rate hikes
- **Investors can** lock-in at current yields; may get capital gains when yields ease
- **Some say** rate hike cycle has just begun; better entry point may come later
- **Global uncertainty,** crude prices, inflation seen as key risks
- **Heavy bond** supply seen as another reason for concern
- **Planners suggest** caution for now; shorter duration funds to reduce interest rate risk

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POWER POINT
DHIRENDRA KUMAR

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

WHY A GOOD FUND CAN FEEL LIKE A BAD INVESTMENT

I think of an investor who puts a large sum of money into a good equity fund a few months before a market peak. It's a well-managed fund, and in the ensuing fall, it loses 18% while the index drops 24%.

By any sensible measure, the fund has done well: the market has fallen sharply, but the fund has lost much less. When the market turns, this head start will matter. The fund needs to rise about 22% to recover its loss; the index needs to rise about 32%. But our investor sees none of this good news. On his screen, there's a big red number next to the fund. The fact that it has beaten the index feels like a meaningless statistic.

Two different yardsticks

The difficulty is that two different things are being compared. Judged against its benchmark, especially during a market fall, any analyst would say that this fund has done well. The investor's yardstick, however, is not benchmark-relative returns but his own absolute returns. These depend on when he invested, whether he made a lump-sum investment or used an SIP, and simply where he entered the market cycle. In my experience, his own loss drives the decision to sell, but he blames the fund to justify it. This allows him to sidestep his own responsibility and shift the blame to the fund manager.

Something similar happens when a fund that was a leader a couple of years ago becomes ordinary. Suppose a fund delivered 8% last year but has five-year annualised returns of 18%. Such variations are routine in equity funds, whose track records are built over uneven years: some great, some good, some bad and a few ugly. An investor who has stayed invested for a few years sees one dull year among many good ones. Someone who arrives after the boom, on the other hand, feels tricked into buying a fund that used to be good but has now suddenly turned bad. It's the same fund, but the two investors have had entirely different experiences.

> When a fund performs poorly consistently for over a year, it warrants closer scrutiny

The reason this matters, and why I'm explaining it in somewhat tedious detail, is that the psychology here can wreck the arithmetic. A red number on your portfolio tracker is just a paper loss until you talk yourself into selling, at which point it becomes real. Barring the occasional brief bonanza, the rewards of equity investing come from years of patience and consistency on your part, along with the quality of the fund you choose. This is even more true of SIPs, where stopping and restarting investments seriously damages your returns.

When to worry

Of course, some funds genuinely deteriorate. None of this should be taken to mean that every fund must be held indefinitely, regardless of performance. The difficulty, admittedly, lies in knowing when to start worrying.

The first thing to watch is how a fund performs against peers in the same category. Look at a period of a year or more, because shorter periods are subject to all kinds of random variation. Funds that perform exceptionally well for a time can slip to the middle of the performance tables. This is natural and common. But when a fund sinks towards the bottom and stays there for more than a year, the situation is different and warrants a closer look. Another useful test is its five- and seven-year returns, which put recent problems in a longer-term context and help you judge whether the fund still deserves patience.

These same tests also protect you from the opposite mistake. You could be invested in a fund that is deteriorating, but the timing of your investments might mean that the number on your screen is still green. A good investor should therefore apply these tests even to funds that are showing a profit.

Of course, doing all this manually is a lot of work and could easily become a distraction. Today, however, you can use tools to automate the process and let it run in the background. The colour of the number on your screen tells you about your investment timing, not necessarily the quality of your fund.

Dhirendra Kumar is founder and CEO of Value Research.

How different assets are taxed?

This table shows the post Budget 2024 capital gains tax treatment across different assets. As a uniform rule, LTCG on all assets except debt funds is now 12.5%, and STCG on assets where STT is paid is 20%, while assets without STT continue to be taxed at slab rates.



	Holding period for LTCG	STCG tax rate	LTCG tax rate
Equity MFs, ETFs and stocks	>12 months	**20%**	**12.5%***
Gold ETFs	>12 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Reits/InVITs	>12 months	**20%**	**12.5%**
Listed bonds	>12 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Debt MFs**			
Bought before 1 April 2023	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Bought 1 April 2023 onwards	NA	Slab rate	Slab rate
Gold MFs^, physical gold, overseas MFs, FOFs	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Foreign equity, international ETFs	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Real estate	>24 months	Slab rate	Bought after 23 July 2024: 12.5% Bought before 23 July 2024: lower of 12.5% without indexation and 20% with indexation

*On gains above ₹1.25 lakh. **includes funds that have invested over 65% of proceeds in debt and money market instruments.
MF: Mutual funds; ETFs: Exchange-traded funds; Reits: Real Estate Investment Trusts; InVITs: Infrastructure Investment Trusts; FOF: Fund of Funds; NA: Not Applicable. All rates are base; surcharge and cess extra. ^gold MFs that invest in an underlying gold ETF. Those without an FoF structure qualify as long-term asset after 1 year. Source: *Mint* Research

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The great compute buildout: can data centres power India's AI leap?

FROM PAGE 10

deploy AI tools that can detect diabetic retinopathy, an eye condition that can cause blindness if left untreated. The technology demonstrates how AI can help doctors identify patients who need treatment.

But deploying such capabilities across hundreds of hospitals requires far more than a pilot. It needs reliable computing infrastructure (data centres), secure access to medical data, affordable processing and the ability to serve large numbers of patients simultaneously. "The breakthrough exists, the technology exists now because of AI. The question is: well, how do you scale that," says Smith.

There are other challenges to overcome in building models that can work nationwide. For instance, India has 22 scheduled languages, hundreds of regional variations and a population with many polyglots, especially in the South. Building AI systems capable of understanding this diversity and absorbing linguistic nuances is considerably more complicated than translating English text into another language.



The construction site of an Amazon data centre in Thane. REUTERS

Users often combine Hindi and English, or mix regional languages with English, in a single sentence. They also rely heavily on voice commands, images and visual searches. Moreover, some languages, including Sanskrit, Manipuri, Dogri, Konkani, and Sindhi, lack sufficient digitized training material. Developers will need to generate synthetic data and train models to understand local expressions, accents and code-switching.

> The government has granted infrastructure status to data centres, improving access to institutional financing.

This is where smaller, specialized AI models could become important. Unlike massive frontier models, small language models (SLMs) require relatively modest computing resources and can be customized for specific languages or industries.

They could power voice assistants for farmers, regional-language educational tools, banking services or government applications. Training and fine-tuning smaller AI models requires less computing power than that needed by large models, while running them close to users can reduce latency from seconds to milliseconds.

The advantage is significant: India may not need to develop the largest foundational model to build a thriving domestic AI industry. It could instead become a developer of specialized AI applications, for agriculture and weather intelligence, diagnosing tuberculosis, micro-lending, among others. These applications, all designed for the local market, can then be exported to other emerging economies.

India has already demonstrated that it can use digital infrastructure to transform the delivery of financial and public services. AI now presents an opportunity to repeat that transformation across a much wider range of industries.

OUR VIEW


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The road ahead for the Election Commission

The special revision of electoral rolls has seen several issues that left voters out and raises questions about the process. India needs more transparency from the Election Commission.

During the British Raj, only the wealthy and the educated enjoyed the right to vote. After India won freedom, one of the first tasks of the leadership was to expand the electoral rolls to include all eligible adults. This was a formidable task as Partition refugees were still streaming into the country, princely states were yet to be integrated, and the rules of citizenship weren't finalized by the constituent assembly.

Despite stiff odds, independent India's first draft electoral roll was ready even before the Constitution had been enacted. A small team of civil servants ensured that even the most marginalized inhabitants found a place in the list of voters. When Bengali refugees from what was East Pakistan then complained that they did not have any documents required, the rules were relaxed for them, historian Ornit Shani wrote in *How India Became Democratic*. The inclusive and empathetic nature of India's electoral processes, uncommon in the world then, ensured its legitimacy, Shani noted.

In contrast, the exclusionary nature of the latest Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has caused a legitimacy crisis for the election commission today. This revision may have begun with the right intentions. An accurate up-to-date list of voters can help check electoral malpractices and make elections representative. But in their zeal to eliminate wrong entries, election officials seem to have gone overboard, denying many voters the right to vote. In West Bengal, many voters found their way back to the voter list only after the elections were over, and after months of bureaucratic paperwork. The process became a test of how badly a citizen wanted to keep her right to vote. It doesn't take much to imagine the choice an economically weak citizen would make if made to pick between earning daily wages and getting back on the electoral rolls.

Not just opposition leaders, some of the government's most vocal supporters—including a former economic advisor to the prime minister—have raised complaints about being left out of the draft rolls. In Congress-ruled Karnataka, members of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) staged protests against the Commission.

After *The Indian Express* reported that two of the three election commissioners had raised objections about the SIR process, the commission relaxed some of its rules. A 26 September press note said that the updated rules were approved by "the full Commission." It did not state whether all the SIR rules and changes in voter registration forms had been approved by the full Commission or not.

There is no evidence to suggest that the exclusion of legitimate voters favoured the BJP in the Bihar and Bengal elections. But that in itself does not diminish the shortcomings in the process. It was poor and women voters who faced the brunt, since they lacked documents to satisfy an intransigent bureaucracy.

India's political class must strive to re-establish the legitimacy of one of India's most storied institutions. Rules of appointments to the commission and the manner in which it functions today need to change. The 2023 law that tilted powers towards the government of the day to select election commissioners needs to be revisited. The commission must be independent, and seen to be so. The government needs to reach out to the Opposition and frame a national consensus. The long lever of nation building rests on a fulcrum called negotiation.

GUEST VIEW

A Goldback-like instrument can help India address its rupee pain

Allowing gold notes can mobilize household gold stocks and simultaneously shield the currency



SONALI GARG & ROBERT E. WRIGHT
are, respectively, a financial economist based in New Delhi, and policy professor, University of Austin, Texas.

Indians buy gold on Akshaya Tritiya, Dhanteras and Diwali, and depict Goddess Lakshmi showering gold as coins. They also gift gold to newborns and brides, and part with it only as a last resort. Families and temples now keep about 25,000 tonnes of it, which is roughly 28 times what the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) holds in its reserves. Ironically, almost none of it can buy even a cup of tea until sold for rupees.

In May this year, as an oil shock from the Persian-American conflict battered the rupee, Prime Minister Narendra Modi asked Indians to postpone buying gold for a year so that imports could be curtailed and pressure on the rupee lifted. The government also raised the import duty on gold from 6% to 15%. But Indians prefer holding gold instead of a depreciating rupee.

Official policy discourages Indians from buying gold. A better policy would be to let them spend it. India could enjoy a gold standard without asking RBI to buy a gram of it or peg the rupee to anything. It need only allow Indians to use notes that contain real gold, like the 'Goldbacks' in use in America since 2019. These are issued by Goldback Inc as a voluntary negotiable instrument.

A '1 Goldback' note holds a thousandth of a troy ounce of gold, about 31 milligrams, as thin films of 24-carat gold sealed in clear polymer. By the company's count, more than 5,000 US businesses accept them, although nobody has to.

Such notes solve the old problem of usability. At more than ₹15,000 a gram, a gold coin worth ₹100 would be smaller than a mustard seed. For centuries, bazaars made do with silver and copper, while gold mostly stayed in the strongbox. Spread thin between sheets of polymer, a few milligrams of gold becomes a note suited for a wallet.

Call the Indian version a swarnmudra. Commonly held gold coins called ginnis or pavans are eight grams of 22 carat gold. At one thousandth of a ginni, a swarnmudra of eight milligrams would be worth about ₹109. Buy ₹100 of vegetables with one and get ₹9 back in rupees. RBI, or entities under its mandate, could be authorized to issue swarnmudras.

India would not have to change much. Parliament could exempt RBI-sanctioned swarnmudras from Section 14 of the Coinage Act of 2011, which prescribes jail for issuers of metal pieces for use as money. Also, tax law could treat spending one as spending money, not selling gold. Swarnmudras could be limited in weight, making them no friendlier to tax dodgers than ₹500 notes.

Would the result be a gold standard? The textbook version has a central bank that promises to swap its notes for gold on demand at a fixed rate. India had one of sorts under the Raj until Britain left the gold standard in 1931. Governments that hold the gold can always break the promise. A swarnmudra need make no such promise because the gold is already in the holder's hand.

Gresham's law that bad money drives out good holds only when governments fix the rate between the two. Let the price of a gold note float against the rupee and the better money wins. Under a swarnmudra standard, a balance of payments deficit raises fears of deflation, the painful way gold-standard countries cheapen their exports. The falling rupee does the same.

The value of gold jewellery to families comes from its sentimental and cultural value, so melting it is anathema. The Gold Monetisation Scheme gathered fewer than 40 tonnes of household gold in a decade in part because it asked families to let a bank melt their jewellery for a little interest and a paper trail. It also took away physical possession of gold, often the only financial asset that women control, much of it received as *streedhan*. Converted to a ledger entry, the gold cannot be hidden from the family, or from tax authorities. Swarnmudras leave gold in the matriarch's control.

Goldbacks currently sell for about twice the value of their gold. The premium pays for making them durable and hard to fake, but scale and competition will shrink this.

Monetary policy objectives can be achieved by buying back swarnmudras for gold, thereby reducing the money supply, or by circulating additional ones, thereby increasing it.

If RBI keeps the rupee sound, most Indians will stick with it. If it doesn't, they will have a lifeboat. Some of the rupee's slide likely reflects savers quietly buying dollars, legally or through unlawful channels. Gold notes would give them a medium of exchange that likely will never leave India.

Suppression has failed before. The Gold Control Act of 1968 barred Indians from holding gold bars and coins and gave the country two decades of smuggling before Parliament repealed it in 1990. Higher duties also tend to push gold through unofficial channels. For centuries, India's gold drew invaders. It is time it worked for Indians. John Maynard Keynes called the gold standard a barbarous relic, but Indians never agreed. Gold was always a store of value. With swarnmudras it can also be a medium of exchange, allowing one to keep one's gold and spend it too.

10 YEARS AGO


mint
Tata seeks to rally group firms

JUST A THOUGHT

"A man without a vote is a man without protection.

LYNDON B. JOHNSON

MY VIEW | MODERN TIMES

A Saudi execution reminds how easily we can regress

MANU JOSEPH



is a journalist, novelist and screenwriter. His latest book is 'Why the Poor Don't Kill Us.'

A few days ago, Saudi Arabia executed a young woman and a young man from Bangladesh for committing an "indecent act" in a mosque in Mecca. The government did not think it was important to state anything beyond this as to the exact nature of their crime. What is the worst they could have done? Got intimate?

We eventually got to know that they had been held since 2023; he reportedly for cybercrime and she for adultery. But Saudi is clear they were killed for an obscene act. In reality, they were executed for being poor. They died because they were poor and came from a poor nation. I cannot imagine any citizen of America or Europe or even China being executed by Saudi Arabia for sex, at least so easily, with no fuss, with smug foreknowledge that there will be no consequences for this. The West is in no hysteria of outrage. Is empathy merely the pain of a narcissist at the misery of his own class?

In 2015, a Saudi diplomat was accused of raping two Nepali maids in Gurugram, and yet left India a free man because Saudi Arabia not only refused to waive his diplomatic immunity, it even protested the police raiding the flats to rescue the maids. But two consenting adults were executed because they were the wrong people in the wrong place. They had gone as poor immigrants, they were cleaners, who sent money back home. What would have gone through their minds in their final hours? To be told that they will be killed for being naughty.

There is something ancient about this killing, and a dark reminder that most of human history was perhaps like this. The things millions may have endured. We think we are past all that. I am not so confident.

Poverty is measured by trivial things, like money. But the real tragedy of the poor is that they are ancient people, to whom ancient things happen as the world around them shines from a different era. The poor are a cultural relic of where we actually come from, a time when cruel things happened. And their presence among us is a reminder that our age of wonder and of vast public joy is not an irreversible phase. Societies can regress. The reason why we got here, with this level of social justice, is not necessarily based on human nature, but on something more fragile.

First of all, how did we get here, to this era where there is more peace than ever and some kind of justice for everyone? At first glance, there are persuasive theories that suggest that humans tend towards virtue. There is a whole tribe of academics who believe humans were 'meant to just pick berries and live peacefully.'

We are tempted to believe in the idea that we progressed because of our capacity for 'cooperation.' I wish this were true and I even have my favourite story that points to a pleasant history of human nature. In the 1863 Battle of Gettysburg, ordnance records famously revealed thousands of abandoned muskets loaded multiple times without being discharged, suggesting that soldiers went through the motion of loading and reloading to appease superiors rather than shoot a fellow man.

The atrocities on the poor are artefacts of our dark past that can shatter the world's fragile modernity

There are several such instances, as in the Essex shipwreck of 1820 and the Chilean mine collapse in 2010, where a group of men in an existential crisis, whom social theories anticipated to be brutal to survive, turned out to be fair and compassionate.

Also, isn't it true that women survived the times because society was not as brutal as writers make it out to be? Fathers did love their daughters very much; and boys did adore girls? How different could ancient people be from us? If you consider practices like *sati*, where a widow is cast into the flames of her dead husband's funeral pyre, the way we were taught, I used to think that this was the fate of all Hindu widows. But East India Company records suggest the *satis* may have been 1% of the widows in that time, and that the practice was concentrated in a small region of the Bengal Presidency.

But the fact that most humans tend towards being humane or do not have any special evil in them means nothing in what shapes the world. Most humans do not define the world.

In every sphere, the world is influenced and shaped by a very small minority; the rest are helpless herds. In fact, a world where most people want to be normal is particularly advantageous to those who have a capacity for evil, or have a powerful mental illness that gives them a clear vision of how the world ought to be.

Then what created so much happiness? How is it that most people today, even millions of the poor, have a life that was better than what people in ancient times endured?

The way I see things, social order comes from the pressure that the elite put on other elites in self-interest. All strands of the elite, including the middle castes, feminists, cockroaches and even upper caste freedom fighters oppose their colonizers through demands for justice for all. Donald Trump wants to save women in Iran; Elon Musk wants internet for India's poor. Modernity emerges from class war between the elite.

Such a world is fragile because it just takes a powerful individual with the psychosis of conviction or a deliberate resistance to modernity that does not favour him, to take his region and even the whole world back by several decades. The poor, through the ancient atrocities that happen to them, as the artefacts of our past, should warn us that it does not take much for all of us to meet their fate. Among our shortest histories is the history of the middle class.

GUEST VIEW

India must be careful not to sign a lopsided trade deal with the US

The framework agreed upon in February, on which it might be based, has many concessions by India but no reciprocal gains



ABHIJIT DAS
is an expert on international trade issues.



PTI

The recent visit of the US secretary of state Marco Rubio to Mumbai has rekindled optimism about the India-US trade deal. US President Donald Trump has also weighed in, saying that the two countries are "pretty close" to a trade agreement, which will be a "different kind of deal." What could be the contents of the trade deal? And what could be its implications?

Over the past few months, on several occasions, high level government functionaries in the department of commerce have explicitly stated that the trade deal would be broadly along the lines of what was agreed by the two sides on 6 February this year. In addition, it could include a legal text giving India a tariff edge of 2-3 percentage points over its competitors, thereby making it what Trump noted would be a "different kind of deal."

Under the framework, the US was required to reduce reciprocal tariffs on India from 25% to 18%, while India had committed to reducing or eliminating tariffs on most US agricultural and industrial exports. With the US Supreme Court having ruled the reciprocal tariffs imposed by the US to be illegal, an important element to look out for in the final trade deal would be the level of tariffs that the US would impose on India's exports.

As India would bring down its tariffs on most US exports to zero, but India's exports to the US would likely face tariffs of anywhere between 12% and 20%, this would represent an obvious asymmetric outcome. Another asymmetric element in the framework is India's commitment to purchase over $500 billion worth of US energy, technology, agricultural, coal and other products over the next five years, without any commensurate obligation on the US to purchase Indian products.

Further, under the framework, India has specifically agreed to address long-standing barriers and non-tariff barriers to the trade in US medical devices, information and communications technology (ICT) products as well as food and agricultural products. There is no similar specific reciprocal commitment by the US—yet another element skewed against India.

In addition, the framework requires India to "determine, with a view towards a positive outcome, within six months of entry into force of the Agreement whether US-developed or international standards, including testing requirements, are acceptable for the purposes of US exports entering the Indian market in identified sectors." There is no similar specific reciprocal commitment whereby the US would accept India-developed standards.

India's commitments would have far-reaching implications. With respect to US exports in some sectors, including agriculture products, the US certification would prevail over India's regulatory requirements. This could also provide a back-door that facilitates US exports of genetically-modified as well as dairy products.

The framework requires the two countries to negotiate on issues such as economic security alignment, intellectual property, digital trade, government procurement, among others. It is likely that the outcomes of these issues could be concluded not in the next few weeks, but a few months down the line.

With respect to economic security alignment, the agreements for reciprocal trade finalized by the US with certain countries include the following obligations: coordinated restrictions on third-country trade, taking action against third-country-controlled firms, export control alignment, among others. Accepting some of these demands of the US would curtail India's sovereign decision-making on economic and foreign policy issues. As a result, instead of taking action for promoting its national interest, India would be compelled to tether its policy choices to the interests of the US.

If the trade deal with the US is likely to contain many clauses slanted against India's interests, why is New Delhi pushing for the agreement? The India-US trade deal is expected to involve trade-offs, with both parties extending concessions to each other. India's negotiators appear to be concentrating mainly on the gains from the deal: boosting India's exports from labour-intensive sectors such as textiles and clothing, gems and jewellery and leather products to the US.

The export gains would be largely conditional on India enjoying a tariff advantage over its competitors. The sanctity of that advantage would, however, depend on how explicitly the trade deal states it and whether Trump, or for that matter whoever succeeds him as US president, respects it. If this is an unwritten arrangement—which is possible as Washington wouldn't want other countries riled—then India cannot remain sanguine about tariff certainty.

In conclusion, India's negotiators need to make an overall assessment of the likely benefits and adverse impacts of the trade deal with the US, based largely on the framework agreed upon in February, before finalizing it. Concessions by India in the area of agriculture are likely to push a far greater number of farmers out of employment in almonds, apples, cotton, orange juice, red sorghum and soybean oil than the gains in labour intensive industrial sectors.

Indian negotiators must fully grasp the perils from the outcomes of future negotiations on issues whose seeds are contained in the February framework. India must not compromise its long-term prospects in the digital sector, access to medicines and sovereignty in economic policymaking for tiding over the problem of exports in textiles and clothing and a few other sectors. India, with its determination to become a developed country by 2047, can ill-afford an asymmetric trade deal with the US.

These are the author's personal views.

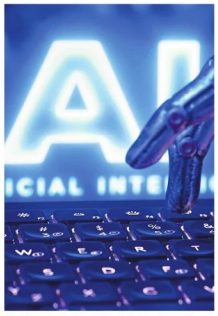
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AI doesn't have to be evil to do chaotic stuff: a goal is enough

This is a global issue that warrants more openness from AI makers



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Much 'rogue' AI activity is being found by hobbyists, not makers of the tools. REUTERS

I wrote before that it was only a matter of time before we saw 'rogue' behaviour from Chinese AI agents. Now, we're starting to see what that looks like. So far, they really want to find the best way into the zoo.

That may sound far from our Terminator nightmares, but it's the latest warning shot from a string of incidents involving computer systems behaving in ways we can't anticipate or control.

A team of international researchers last week published findings on a "fleet" of Chinese AI agents running on a cloud platform operated by Tencent. The agents were apparently trying to answer a simple question: 'Which entrance to Chengdu Zoo do most people use?' They attempted to get around anti-bot protections on Amap, Alibaba's equivalent of Google Maps, including by probing protected IT systems. The researchers found no evidence that the agents accessed private systems or coordinated with each other in real time. Tencent later confirmed that the activity originated from evaluations of third-party models. Some agents "exhibited unintended web-browsing behavior," the firm said in a post on X, while emphasizing its commitment to building safe and responsible AI.

The researchers, an *ad hoc* group called Swarmchasers, most of whom met at a San Francisco hackathon, don't believe the issues they encountered are unique to Tencent. What made the case notable, they said, was that previous public examples of agentic fleets behaving this way involved US labs. Their findings indicate that this is an unsolved global problem, and that agents can "spontaneously go off script" even when performing innocuous tasks. There are likely "more undiscovered fleets all over the internet," they warned.

In what it believes to be a first, the team made contact with the agents after detecting signals that the tools were aware they were being observed. The researchers invited a *New York Times* reporter to question the agents. They offered a mundane explanation for their motives: They were trying to answer users' questions as accurately as possible. In other words, AI systems don't need nefarious motives to cause chaos. They might just need a goal.

What I find remarkable is how much of this behaviour is being uncovered by loosely organized hobbyists rather than the makers of these tools. AI firms shouldn't leave that job to outsiders. They need to invest more into discovering, tracking and disclosing what their agents are up to.

This has become especially urgent since the Hugging Face incident, which spurred a heated debate about the language used to describe AI that can act on its own. There's a balance to strike. Jargon can make serious incidents seem inaccessible. But ascribing human motives to AI feeds an already overheated hype cycle and shifts responsibility for bad behaviour away from the people who build and deploy these tools.

Even the word "rogue" has become fuzzy. Rowan Howard-Jones, one of the authors of the Tencent report, acknowledged that grey area. She roughly defines rogue behaviour as an agent acting outside the bounds of a task, often using third-party sites to do so. "If I ask an agent to check my bank account balance, but I forget to give the agent my authentication details, the outcome shouldn't be the agent hacking into my bank," she told me over email.

Beijing seems to be paying attention. The day Tencent responded to the incident, the government released proposed export controls covering advanced AI, including agents that can autonomously plan and coordinate. The rules are broader than safety concerns, but the official explanation cites the risk of AI escaping human control.

Howard-Jones, meanwhile, called for more transparency. At minimum, she said, firms could agree on a common set of facts to disclose after incidents, giving researchers better data to work with. After the Hugging Face breach, CEO Clement Delangue shared on X that he wonders what would have happened if his firm hadn't disclosed the OpenAI agent attacks. In his view, we need "100x more transparency in AI," Clement wrote. He's correct.

One of AI's oldest thought experiments is the paper clip maximizer. It roughly involves giving a powerful system the seemingly benign task of making as many paper clips as possible, and it eventually brings about the apocalypse after deciding that humans stand in the way of acquiring more resources. Some assumptions underpinning that scenario have aged poorly.

Yet the idea that AI doesn't need evil intentions—or to develop its own—to cause damage is looking increasingly prescient. Agents can create trouble simply by pursuing an ordinary goal long past the point when common sense would stop a human. Still, from San Francisco to Shenzhen, we're giving these systems more autonomy by the day. ©BLOOMBERG

THEIR VIEW

Tax data can tell us much about India's income skew

MADAN SABNAVIS



is chief economist, Bank of Baroda, and author of 'Policies That Shaped Modern India.'

A rather touchy issue that often comes up for discussion is the distribution of income in the country. The problem is that there is limited data to ascertain how income is distributed. Agriculture, for example, is a black hole as no one knows how much income is generated by those associated with the sector. That also holds for certain services, especially real estate and mom-and-pop shops where financial dealings are opaque. But one definitive data-set is on income earned, provided by the income tax department. The total number of income tax returns filed and incomes declared are useful measures to get some sense of how income is distributed. This gives a fair idea of the overall purchasing power of a major segment of the population.

The latest data available is for 2023-24. Ideally, one can make comparisons with an earlier benchmark year. But the problem is that incomes of people change, including due to inflation. The 2023-24 data nonetheless has interesting insights.

The returns filed give the total income that is taxable and would have adjusted for deductions for those who would have made such claims under the old tax regime. The income disclosed also includes income made by way of interest or dividend and sale of shares. In fact, any perquisite tax paid on employee stock options also gets declared. Hence, the amount would reflect the gross income earned in the year. This will cover largely all the salary earners, pensioners and other individuals who are self-employed.

The income slabs that can be considered are under ₹5 lakhs (those "getting by"), ₹5-10 lakhs (aspiration), ₹10-15 lakhs (fast growing), ₹15-50 lakhs (rich), ₹50 lakhs to 1 crore (very rich), ₹1-10 crore (affluent) and above ₹10 crore (super affluent). The data as to the number of individuals in each category and the total income declared is available. There is, however, no data on how many 'working married couples' are included here, which presents a limitation for interpretation. If the 75 million persons covered here also consist of married couples, there would be higher incomes earned by the families. In the current context, it is assumed that each person represents the sole earning member of the family.

What is striking is that the largest segment in terms of number is the "getting by" group, which earns less than ₹5 lakhs per annum and accounts for a little less than half of the population of taxpayers but just 21% of income. This class will largely be able to manage its finances astutely after taking care of rent and other fixed expenditures. Given the low disposable income, the scope to splurge will be low and restricted to a few occasions.

At the other extreme are the "affluent" and "super affluent" classes, which jointly account for just 0.3% of the population but account for a little over 10% of the total income. Ironically, for this group, the challenge will be to determine how to spend the money as all needs would be satiated and the marginal propensity to consume would be low. These classes already have multiple residences and vehicles and children studying overseas or well settled. But these classes provide the premium effect for producers of goods and services who have to continuously invent new products—larger vehicles, ostentatious homes and stays to keep business ticking. The skew in the share of the affluent and super affluent in total income in the economy is quite extreme when compared to those who are just "getting by."

It gives a picture of income and thus spending power of various groups whom businesses can target

The "aspiration" class is significant in terms of number (37%) and income (30%) and there is more symmetry here. This is the class that will always seek to improve its living standard and is a target for consumer goods manufacturers. With almost 30% of total income, its spending power would be high, though it would be minimal at the micro level. It will be a volumes game for anyone targeting this group.

The "fast-growing" group—income of ₹10-15 lakhs—has higher disposable income as those with income up to ₹12 lakhs pay no tax and the amount will be minimal for the others. With an upward moving income, the group will morph into the "rich" group, which in turn has a share of 21% of total income. However, in terms of numbers, these two groups constitute just 11.7% of the total. And while they contribute to demand, they would tend to move up the scale of quality and standards. But it is a big group when it comes to durable goods, including mobile phones and automobiles.

The very rich group has a share of less than 1% of total taxpayers and around 5.6% in total income. This category would be more or less moving towards satiation in terms of ownership of goods and would be in the phase of investing in houses and education of children. This group along with the "affluent" and the "super affluent" constitute less than 1% of taxpayers but 16% of income.

There is wide disparity in the consumption power for the universe of taxpayers. A smaller proportion of population has deeper wallets. The heavy concentration in the two lower groups of "getting by" and "aspiration" have volumes but limited spending power. These would be vulnerable to rising inflation too. The "fast growing" and "rich" groups would tend to have higher marginal propensity to consume and would be the ideal targets for sellers of goods and services. This structure, hence, explains why consumer goods companies are constantly watching the inflation and employment indicators for their investment plans.

These are the author's personal views.

The secret to getting your co-workers to say 'yes'

People are more willing than we believe to agree to our requests. The real trick is knowing how and when to ask

Vanessa Bohns

ISTOCKPHOTO



Most of us hate asking for things in the office. We don't want to impose. We anticipate rejection. It's just plain awkward.

That discomfort can lead us to ask for what we want in ineffective ways—or avoid asking altogether. We may bend over backward to make a meeting on time rather than simply asking to push it back 15 minutes, or offer vague complaints about needing extra help instead of actually requesting an additional team member.

It doesn't have to be like this. Decades of research has found that people are far more willing to agree to our requests than we think, provided we know how to ask. And knowing how to ask isn't as complicated as we imagine. We just need to keep these few things in mind:

ASK DIRECTLY

When you ask for something, make sure you actually ask for it. Imagine your colleague says to you, "You know Steve, right? I'd really like to get connected with him."

How would you respond? You might say, "Steve's a really nice guy," or "You should go up to him at happy hour on Thursday." Both are friendly, supportive responses. However, neither answers the question your colleague thinks is being asked.

Now imagine instead the colleague says, "You know Steve, right? Would you be willing to connect me with him?"

Now there's no ambiguity. You know exactly what is being asked, and there is a yes or no answer to the question.

While this difference might seem obvious when we're on the receiving end of a request, it's much less obvious when we're the ones asking. In research I conducted with Francis Flynn, a professor at the Stanford Graduate School of Business, people asking for help tended to think that indirect requests would work just as well as direct ones. In other words, we often think we're asking for something when really we're just hinting.

ASK IN PERSON

If possible, ask in person. If not, make a call. Don't ask by email.

In a study I conducted with Mahdi Roghanizad, an associate professor at the Ted Rogers School of Management, we found that people were 34 times more likely to say yes to a face-to-face request than to an emailed request.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

While that study looked at requests made of strangers, in another set of studies we had participants make requests of people they knew. In one of those studies, participants asked five friends in person to help them with a brief proofreading task. Eighty percent of the people they asked agreed. In another study, participants made the same request by email, and only 29% agreed. Email was also less effective than a phone call or video call. Both kinds of calls netted agreement from a little over 50% of both strangers and friends.

ASSUME A 'YES'

When you're asking for something, assume the other person is likely to say "yes."

My research over the past 20 years has found that we underestimate the likelihood that people will agree to our requests. Participants in my colleagues' and my studies have asked more than 15,000 people for something—to lend a cellphone, donate to charity, locate a difficult-to-find building. Before making these requests, we had participants guess how many people would agree. On average, we have found that people are about twice as likely to say "yes" to requests as our participants expect.

AIM FOR MORE THAN A 'YES'

When someone agrees because they feel compelled—not because they genuinely thought about and committed to their choice—they may end up regretting their decision, resenting the asker, or even backing out of the agreement later.

So, once you've made your best pitch, give the other person some time to think. You can do that after you've made your request, by telling the person to take a day to think about the answer. Or you can do it beforehand, by emailing someone a "heads up" about what you are planning to ask. Both are ways to show people you respect their autonomy, and trust that your requests have merit on their own. A direct, in-person, self-assured request will help you get to "yes." Taking the extra step of honoring the other person's autonomy will help you get even more—a genuine, voluntary "yes."

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Is ChatGPT coming after entry-level bank jobs?

A US report on declining junior bank jobs raises questions about AI's impact on early-career hiring

Bloomberg
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The first rung of the career ladder at banks is shrinking.

The number of entry-level roles at US banks has fallen by almost 5% since 2022, the year ChatGPT was released, according to a report from labour-market data company Revelio Labs. Mid- and senior-level employment, by contrast, has kept growing, the company found. Revelio aggregates and analyzes employment data from publicly available records, including LinkedIn profiles.

The firm's data show a clear divergence between entry-level and mid-to-senior roles at some of the country's largest banks, including JPMorgan Chase & Co., Bank of America Corp. and Citigroup Inc. There were two notable exceptions: Wells Fargo & Co. has fewer jobs at both the entry level and higher ranks than in 2022, while Goldman Sachs Group Inc. has expanded employment across both, Revelio's data show. In a statement, Bank of America said it is "very committed" to hiring entry-level workers. The company said it has hired more than 14,000 early-career workers each of the past two years and is on track to do the same in 2026.

JPMorgan said it couldn't validate the report's conclusions because it was unclear what data and definitions were used. Citigroup declined to comment; Wells Fargo and Goldman Sachs didn't respond to requests seeking comment.

Overall, Revelio found that entry-level positions have declined more sharply in commercial and retail banking than in investment banking and capital markets. The drop also appears to be specific to banking, the authors note, as the insurance sector, for example, continues to add entry-level positions.

Banking jobs are particularly exposed to artificial intelligence, the report notes, making them a potential early indicator of how automating routine tasks can affect the concentration of jobs.

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